

Youth Unemployment in Lebanon

Bridging the Gap Between Graduate Job Seekers and Employer Requirements

Statistical Descriptive and Comparative Study

Prepared by

Batoul Blaybel

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Graduate Job Seekers and Employers in Lebanon

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1 Executive Summary

Youth unemployment in Lebanon is shaped by an interaction between the circumstances of graduate job seekers and the requirements and practices of employers. This study examines both perspectives using two complementary survey datasets: 83 valid responses from graduate job seekers and unemployed youth and 36 valid responses from employers involved in recruitment. A descriptive and comparative approach was used to examine education, employment status, job-search behavior, barriers, skills, employer requirements, recruitment practices, hiring difficulties, and potential solutions.

The youth results show that 59.0% of respondents were unemployed and actively looking for work, while 43.4% identified lack of practical work experience as a barrier and 42.2% identified the location of available jobs as a barrier. Access to opportunities was driven mainly by online job platforms (65.1%), social media (47.0%), LinkedIn or other professional platforms (43.4%), and friends or family (42.2%), while universities and direct employer outreach were each reported by only 8.4% of respondents. The employer results show that hiring difficulties were concentrated around candidate quality and alignment: 69.4% reported receiving many applications but few candidates who met the requirements, 50.0% reported insufficient experience, and 44.4% reported insufficient skills.

The comparison identifies clear alignment around the importance of practical experience, technical skills, job-specific training, and employer networking. At the same time, it reveals important differences in priorities. Youth placed greater emphasis on paid internships (65.1%) than employers did on internships or apprenticeships (30.6%), whereas employers placed greater emphasis on career guidance (36.1%) than youth did (9.6%). Employers also rated communication and problem-solving highly, while relatively few youth identified these competencies as missing. These differences should be interpreted as potential gaps in preparedness, perception, and access rather than as proof that young people necessarily lack the relevant skills.

Overall, the findings indicate that youth unemployment cannot be addressed through skills development alone. Effective responses should combine employment readiness and job-specific training with structured practical experience, career guidance, employer networking, skills-based job matching, stronger university–employer partnerships, and improved compensation and working conditions. Because the study is descriptive and based on survey responses, the findings describe patterns in the sample and do not establish causal relationships.

Key findings

1. **Practical experience is a central transition barrier.** Lack of practical work experience was reported by 43.4% of youth, while 80.5% of employers rated practical experience as at least moderately important. This alignment indicates that limited workplace exposure is a major point of friction between education and employment.
2. **Employers prioritize demonstrated workplace competencies.** Communication skills were identified as a reason for non-selection by 50.0% of employers, followed by insufficient technical or job-specific skills (44.4%) and lack of practical experience (38.9%). Employers also rated adaptability, communication, technical skills, and problem-solving as highly important.
3. **The main employer difficulty is candidate–requirement mismatch rather than a lack of applicants.** Although 69.4% of employers reported many applicants but few meeting

requirements, 50.0% also reported insufficient experience and 44.4% insufficient skills among candidates.

4. **Youth and employers do not always prioritize the same solutions.** Youth most strongly favored paid internships, whereas employers more frequently selected better compensation and career guidance. This difference supports a two-sided intervention model that combines practical access for youth with stronger preparation and clearer pathways for employers.

Key recommendations

1. Develop structured, accessible, and preferably paid internships, apprenticeships, employer-led projects, and other forms of practical work experience so that young people can apply their skills and demonstrate their capabilities.
2. Provide job-specific employment-readiness programs that combine technical and digital competencies with communication, problem-solving, adaptability, language skills, CV preparation, and interview practice. Employers should contribute to the design of this training so that it reflects actual vacancies.
3. Strengthen career guidance, mentorship, employer networking, and professional exposure, particularly for young people who lack established networks. Universities and employment-support organizations should create continuous connections with employers rather than relying only on occasional recruitment events.
4. Establish more effective skills-based job-matching and placement mechanisms that make candidate capabilities and employer requirements transparent, expand access beyond informal networks, and improve the transition from training to employment.
5. Encourage employers to expand entry-level pathways and improve compensation, working conditions, and retention prospects. Government, universities, and employment-support organizations should facilitate partnerships and reduce practical barriers such as location, transportation, and limited access to employment services.

2 Introduction

Youth unemployment is an important labor-market and socioeconomic challenge in Lebanon. For many young graduates, the transition from higher education to employment is not straightforward. Obtaining a degree does not necessarily translate into access to suitable employment, particularly when young job seekers face limited opportunities to gain practical experience, develop market-relevant skills, access professional networks, or identify appropriate vacancies.

At the same time, the employment problem cannot be understood solely from the perspective of job seekers. Employers also face challenges when recruiting young people. These challenges may include difficulties finding candidates with the required technical or interpersonal skills, limited practical experience among applicants, salary and working-condition expectations, recruitment constraints, and difficulties reaching suitable candidates.

For this reason, examining only the characteristics of unemployed youth provides an incomplete picture of the labor-market problem. A more complete understanding requires examining both sides of the labor market and considering how the supply of potential workers interacts with employer demand.

The central issue examined in this study is therefore a possible mismatch between what graduate job seekers bring to the labor market and what employers expect from candidates. Such a mismatch may involve skills and experience, but it may also concern access to employment opportunities, recruitment channels, expectations, information, and the structure of entry-level employment.

2.1 Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this study is to examine youth unemployment in Lebanon from both the graduate job-seeker and employer perspectives. The study seeks to identify the characteristics and employment barriers of graduate job seekers, understand employer requirements and recruitment practices, and compare the two perspectives to identify areas of alignment and mismatch.

The broader objective is to move beyond viewing unemployment as solely a problem of individual employability and instead examine the interaction between job-seeker capabilities, employer expectations, recruitment practices, and access to employment opportunities.

2.2 Research Questions

The study addresses the following central research question:

To what extent is there a gap between the characteristics, expectations, and employment barriers of graduate job seekers and the requirements and hiring practices of employers in Lebanon?

The study also addresses the following supporting questions:

1. Who are the graduate job seekers represented in the study, in terms of educational, and employment characteristics?
2. What are the main barriers that graduate job seekers report when attempting to obtain employment?
3. What characteristics, skills, experience, and qualifications do employers consider important when hiring young people?

4. What recruitment channels and hiring practices do employers use?
5. What difficulties do employers experience when recruiting young people?
6. Where do the perspectives of graduate job seekers and employers align?
7. Where do the two perspectives diverge?
8. What major gaps or mismatches can be identified between the two sides of the labor market?
9. What interventions could potentially help bridge the identified gaps?

3 Methodology

3.1 Study Design

This study uses a descriptive and comparative research approach based on two complementary perspectives of the Lebanese labor market.

The first perspective focuses on young job seekers and unemployed youth aged 20-30, examining their educational backgrounds, employment histories, skills and training, job-search behavior, employment preferences, and perceived barriers to employment.

The second perspective focuses on employers involved in recruitment, examining their organizational characteristics, recruitment practices, hiring requirements, perceptions of young candidates, hiring difficulties, and approaches to addressing skill gaps.

The two datasets are first analyzed separately to establish a clear understanding of each perspective. The findings are then compared to identify areas of alignment and divergence between the experiences and reported barriers of young job seekers and the requirements and expectations of employers. This comparison is used to highlight potential gaps between the supply of skills and experience among young job seekers and the requirements of the labor market.

3.2 Data Collection

3.2.1 Youth Survey

The youth survey targeted graduate job seekers and unemployed youth in Lebanon. The questionnaire collected information on respondents' education, employment background, job-search behavior, employment preferences, skills and training, and perceived barriers to employment.

The final youth dataset contains:

83 valid responses.

The data were collected through a structured survey questionnaire.

3.2.2 Employer Survey

The employer survey targeted individuals involved in recruitment and employment decisions, including human-resource professionals, recruiters, hiring managers, team leaders, department heads, owners, and founders.

The questionnaire examined employer characteristics, youth hiring, recruitment sources, interview criteria, reasons candidates are not selected, skill requirements, previous experience requirements, hiring challenges, and possible approaches for improving youth employment.

The final employer dataset contains:

36 valid responses.

The data were collected through a structured survey questionnaire.

3.3 Variables and Measures

The study covers several dimensions of the transition from education to employment.

Youth Perspective

Education and specialization

Education level, field of study, and professional specialization.

Employment situation

Employment status, job-search situation, and employment preferences.

Job search and applications

Search duration, applications, and access to opportunities.

Employment barriers

Experience, skills, networks, discrimination, location, transportation, salary, and other perceived barriers.

Skills and preparedness

Technical and digital skills, soft skills, languages, practical experience, certifications, and training preparedness.

Recruitment perceptions

Perceived employer requirements, connections, referrals, interviews, and rejection experiences.

Job quality and opportunities

Salary, security, working conditions, career progression, remote work, freelancing, and international opportunities.

Support and solutions

Internships, training, career guidance, job matching, networking, mentorship, and other forms of support.

Employer Perspective

Employer requirements

Technical skills, practical experience, communication, problem-solving, adaptability, education, internships, and language skills.

Recruitment practices

Recruitment sources, interviews, referrals, universities, job platforms, internships, and professional networks.

Candidate assessment

Factors considered when evaluating young candidates during recruitment and selection.

Hiring difficulties

Skill shortages, experience requirements, candidate availability, salary expectations, and applicant quality.

Skills gaps

Difficulties finding candidates with the technical, practical, digital, communication, and other skills required.

Entry-level opportunities

Availability of opportunities for young candidates, internships, and pathways into employment.

Workplace expectations

Expectations regarding qualifications, experience, adaptability, communication, and professional readiness.

Approaches to skill gaps

Training, internships, mentorship, recruitment strategies, and other approaches used to address skill shortages.

Figure 1: Dimensions examined across the youth and employer perspectives.

3.4 Data Analysis

The analysis follows a primarily descriptive and comparative approach, with the two datasets initially examined separately and subsequently compared across dimensions that can be meaningfully aligned.

The following methods are used:

- *Frequencies and percentages* to summarize categorical variables and describe the distribution of responses.
- *Median and/or frequencies* were used to summarize ordinal variables and represent the central tendency of ordered responses.
- *Cross-tabulations* to examine response patterns across relevant variables within the datasets.
- *Graphical representations*, including bar charts, ranked distributions, and comparative visualizations, to facilitate interpretation of the main findings.
- *Descriptive comparisons* between youth and employer responses to identify areas of alignment and divergence.
- *Gap analysis* to compare relevant dimensions across the two datasets and identify potential differences between young job seekers' reported experiences, skills, expectations, and barriers and employers' reported requirements, expectations, and hiring challenges.

The analysis is intended to describe and compare patterns observed within the study data rather than establish statistically significant relationships or causal effects. Inferential statistical tests are therefore not included in the main analysis. Findings are interpreted descriptively, with emphasis placed on identifying recurring patterns, areas of alignment and divergence, and potential areas for intervention.

4 Profile of Graduate Job Seekers

This section describes the educational background, employment situation, job-search experience, and career-related characteristics of the graduate job seekers included in the study. The objective is to establish the profile of respondents before examining the barriers they face and comparing their experiences with employer perspectives.

4.1 Current Employment Situation

4.1.1 Current Situation

Current Employment Situation	Count	Percentage
Unemployed – actively looking for work	49	59.0%
Freelancing/temporary/informal work – seeking stable employment	11	13.3%
Unemployed – not actively looking	9	10.8%
Working – seeking better career opportunities, stability, or conditions	8	9.6%
Other	6	7.2%

Table 1: Current employment situation of youth respondents.

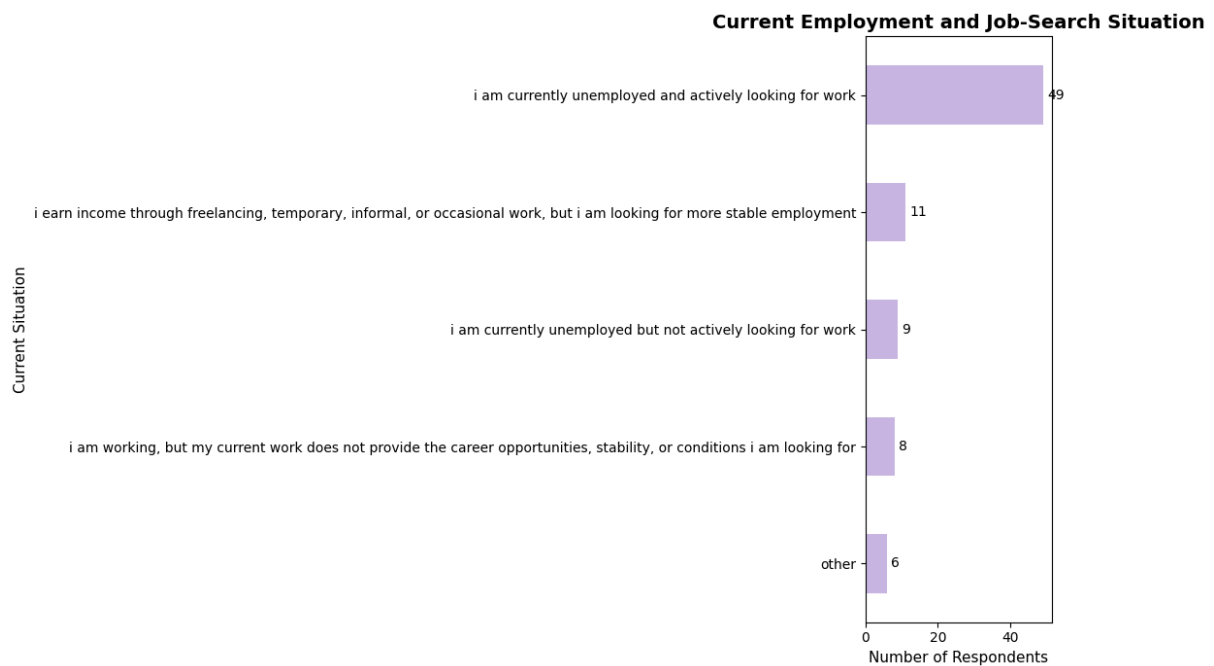


Figure 2: Current employment and job-search situation of respondents.

The results show that most respondents are currently unemployed and actively looking for work, accounting for 49 of the 83 respondents (59%). This is followed by respondents who earn income through freelancing, temporary, informal, or occasional work while seeking more stable employment, with 11 respondents (13.3%). Together, these findings indicate that a substantial proportion of youth are either outside stable employment or seeking to transition into more secure work. The presence of respondents who are unemployed but not actively searching, as well as those who are employed but seeking better career opportunities, further suggests that the employment challenge extends beyond unemployment alone to include difficulties in accessing stable and satisfactory employment.

4.2 Job Search and Applications

4.2.1 Duration of Job Search

Duration of Job Search	Count	Percentage
Less than 3 months	19	27.5%
3–6 months	13	18.8%
6–12 months	16	23.2%
More than 1 year	13	18.8%
More than 2 years	8	11.6%

Table 2: Duration of job search among youth respondents.

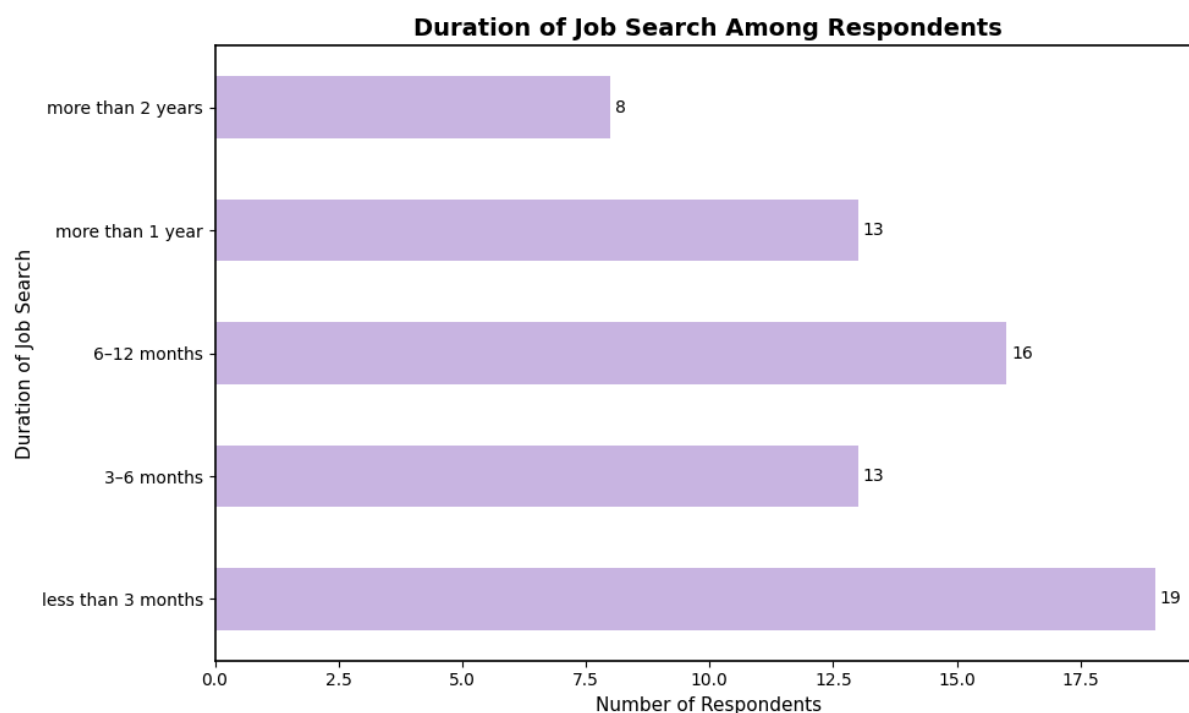


Figure 3: Duration of job search among respondents.

Figure 3 presents the duration of job searching among respondents who are actively seeking employment. The largest group has been searching for less than three months (27.5%), followed by those searching for 6–12 months (23.2%). Overall, 69.6% of active job seekers have been searching for less than one year, while 30.4% have been searching for more than one year, including 11.6% who have been searching for more than two years. This indicates that while many respondents are relatively recent

entrants to the job-search process, a substantial proportion are experiencing prolonged unemployment and difficulty transitioning into employment.

4.2.2 Number of Job Applications

Number of Job Applications	Count	Percentage
None	21	25.3%
1–5	26	31.3%
6–10	12	14.5%
11–20	7	8.4%
More than 20	17	20.5%

Table 3: Number of job applications submitted by youth respondents.

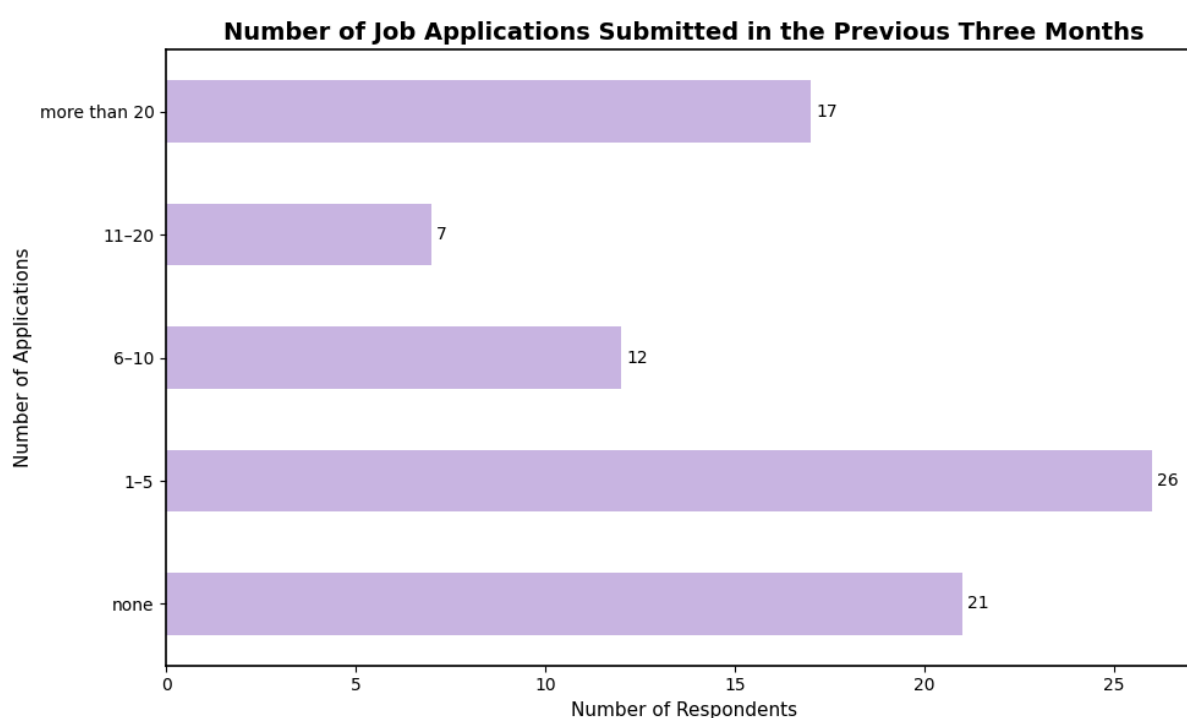


Figure 4: Approximate number of job applications submitted during the previous three months.

Figure 4 presents the number of job applications submitted by respondents during the past three months. The results show considerable variation in job-search activity. While 31.3% of respondents submitted between 1 and 5 applications, 25.3% reported submitting none, indicating that a substantial proportion had limited or no application activity during the period. At the same time, 28.9% submitted more than 10 applications, including 20.5% who submitted more than 20, reflecting a high level of application activity among another segment of respondents. Overall, the findings suggest that youth engagement in the job-search process varies considerably, with some respondents actively applying for multiple positions while others show limited application activity. This distribution describes application behavior only and does not indicate whether applications resulted in interviews or employment.

4.3 Access to Employment Opportunities

This section examines how graduate job seekers access information about employment opportunities and the channels through which they encounter potential jobs.

4.3.1 Sources of Employment Opportunities

Source of Employment Opportunities	Count	Percentage
Online job platforms / web-sites	54	65.1%
Social media	39	47.0%
LinkedIn or professional platforms	36	43.4%
Friends or family	35	42.2%
Personal or professional connections	14	16.9%
I rarely hear about suitable opportunities	14	16.9%
NGO or community organization	14	16.9%
University / educational institution	7	8.4%
Directly from employers	7	8.4%
Recruitment agency	5	6.0%
Other	1	1.2%

Table 4: Sources through which youth respondents access employment opportunities. Multiple responses were permitted; percentages are calculated based on the total sample (N = 83) and therefore do not sum to 100%.

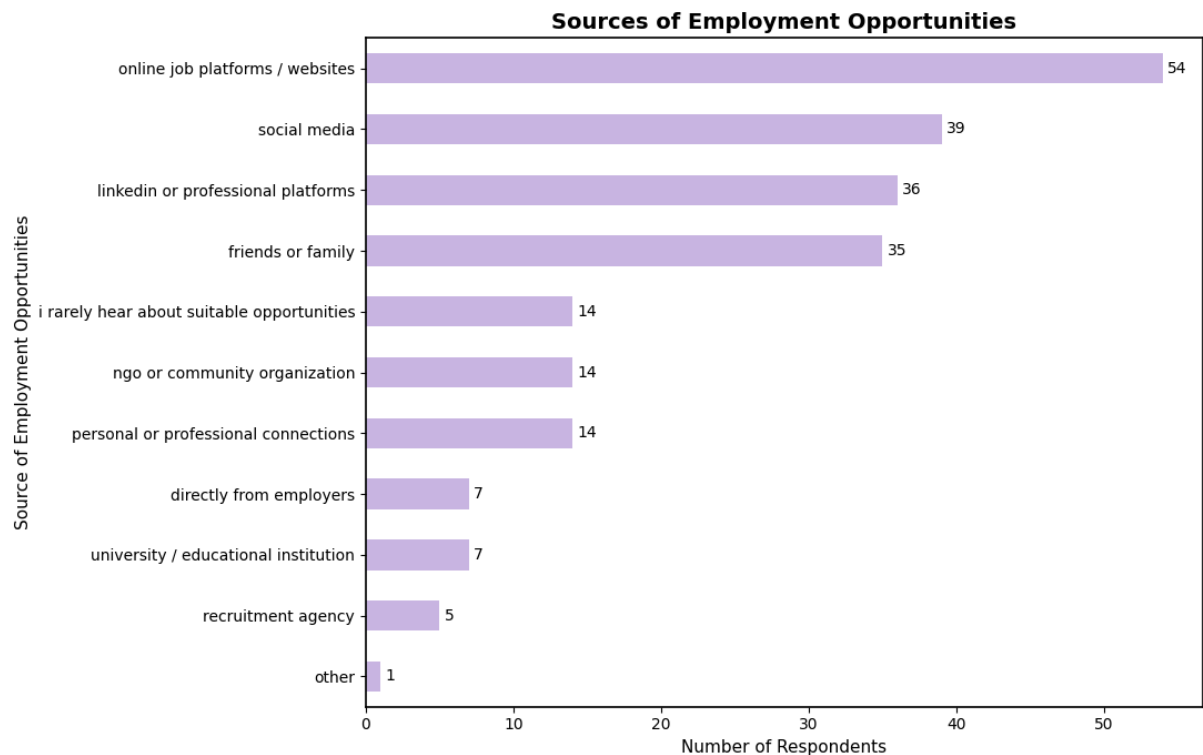


Figure 5: Sources through which respondents hear about suitable employment opportunities.

Figure 5 presents the sources through which respondents learn about suitable job opportunities. The findings indicate a strong reliance on digital channels, particularly online job platforms, social media, and professional networking platforms. Informal networks, such as friends and family, also represent an important pathway through which respondents access employment opportunities. In contrast, universities, direct employer outreach, and recruitment agencies are reported less frequently.

Overall, the results suggest that access to employment opportunities is largely driven by digital platforms and personal networks rather than institutional or employer-led channels. This may indicate a limited connection between youth and formal employment-support or recruitment mechanisms, highlighting the importance of examining whether existing channels effectively connect young job seekers with employers. Since multiple responses were permitted, the percentages represent the proportion of respondents selecting each source and therefore do not sum to 100%.

4.4 Barriers to Employment

Barrier to Employment	Count	Percentage
Lack of practical work experience	36	43.4%
Location of available jobs / distance from where respondents live	35	42.2%
High competition for available positions	32	38.6%
Limited job opportunities in their field	28	33.7%
Transportation or commuting difficulties	21	25.3%
Salary levels offered by employers	19	22.9%
Lack of professional connections or networking opportunities	18	21.7%
Discrimination or bias during the hiring process	17	20.5%
Stress, discouragement, or loss of motivation	10	12.0%
Lack of technical or digital skills	9	10.8%
Lack of soft skills	4	4.8%
None of the above	1	1.2%

Table 5: Barriers to employment reported by youth respondents. Multiple responses were permitted; percentages are calculated based on the total sample (N = 83) and therefore do not sum to 100%.



Figure 6: Barriers to employment reported by graduate job seekers.

Figure 6 presents the main barriers faced by respondents during their job search. The results show that employment difficulties are driven primarily by practical and access-related constraints, particularly lack of practical work experience (43.4%), location of available jobs (42.2%), high competition (38.6%), and limited opportunities in respondents' fields (33.7%). In contrast, relatively few respondents identified technical or digital skills (10.8%) or soft skills (4.8%) as barriers. Notably, lack of practical work experience was also the most frequently reported single biggest difficulty (24.1%), reinforcing its importance in respondents' employment challenges. Overall, the findings suggest that barriers related to experience, access, and availability of suitable opportunities are more prominent than self-reported skills deficiencies.

4.5 Where the Employment Process Breaks Down

This section examines the stages of the employment process at which graduate job seekers experience the greatest difficulty.

4.5.1 Most Difficult Stage

Most Difficult Stage	Count	Percentage
Finding suitable job opportunities	27	32.5%
I have not yet reached any of these stages	19	22.9%
Receiving a job offer	10	12.0%
Getting invited to interviews	9	10.8%
Deciding which opportunities to apply for	6	7.2%
Accepting an available offer because of salary or other conditions	5	6.0%
Performing well in interviews or assessments	4	4.8%
Completing job applications	2	2.4%
Staying in a job once hired	1	1.2%

Table 6: Most Difficult Stage in the Employment Process

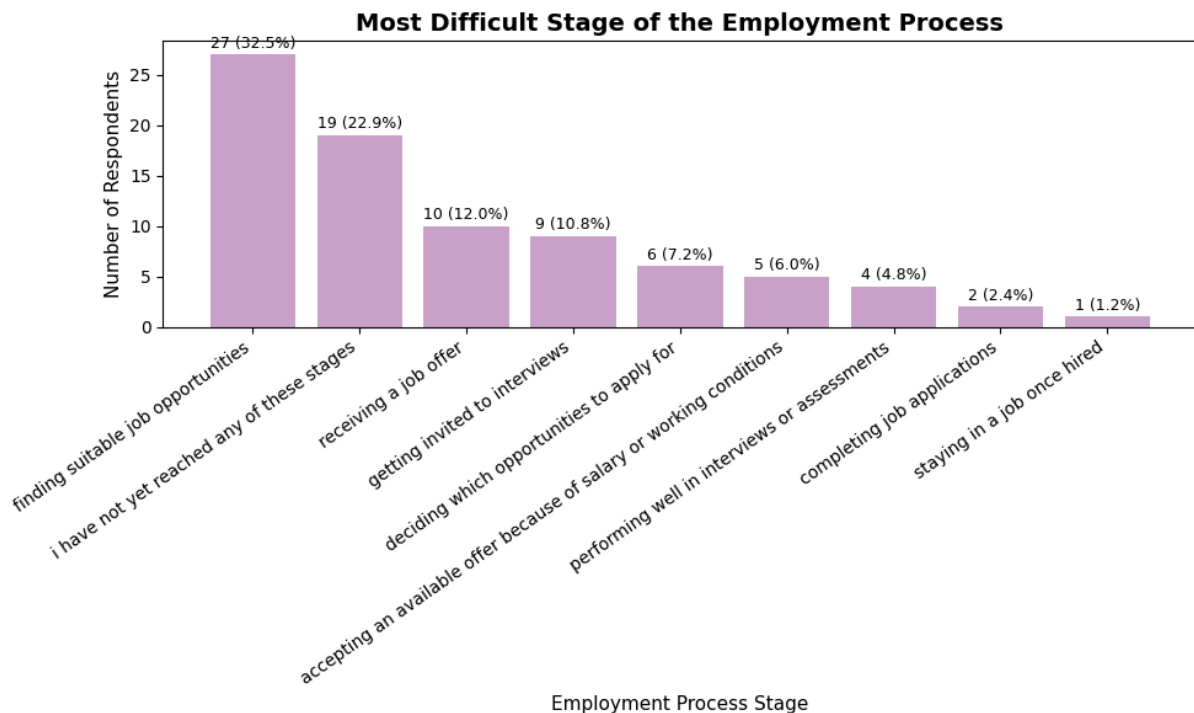


Figure 7: Stages of the employment process at which respondents experience the greatest difficulty.

Figure 7 presents the stage of the job-search process that respondents find most difficult. Finding suitable job opportunities was the most frequently reported difficulty (32.5%), indicating that many respondents struggle at the initial stage of identifying vacancies that match their qualifications and

career goals. A further 22.9% had not yet reached any of the listed stages, while among those who progressed further, receiving a job offer (12.0%) and obtaining an interview (10.8%) were the most commonly reported difficulties. Overall, the findings suggest that challenges are concentrated mainly in accessing suitable opportunities and progressing through the recruitment process, rather than in completing applications or remaining employed once hired.

4.5.2 Outcomes After Job Applications

Application Outcome	Count	Percentage
I rarely receive any response	36	43.4%
I sometimes receive interviews but rarely progress further	12	14.5%
I have received offers, but they were not suitable	11	13.3%
I often reach later stages but do not receive offers	9	10.8%
I receive rejections without an interview	8	9.6%
I have received suitable offers but could not accept them	7	8.4%

Table 7: Typical Outcomes Following Job Applications

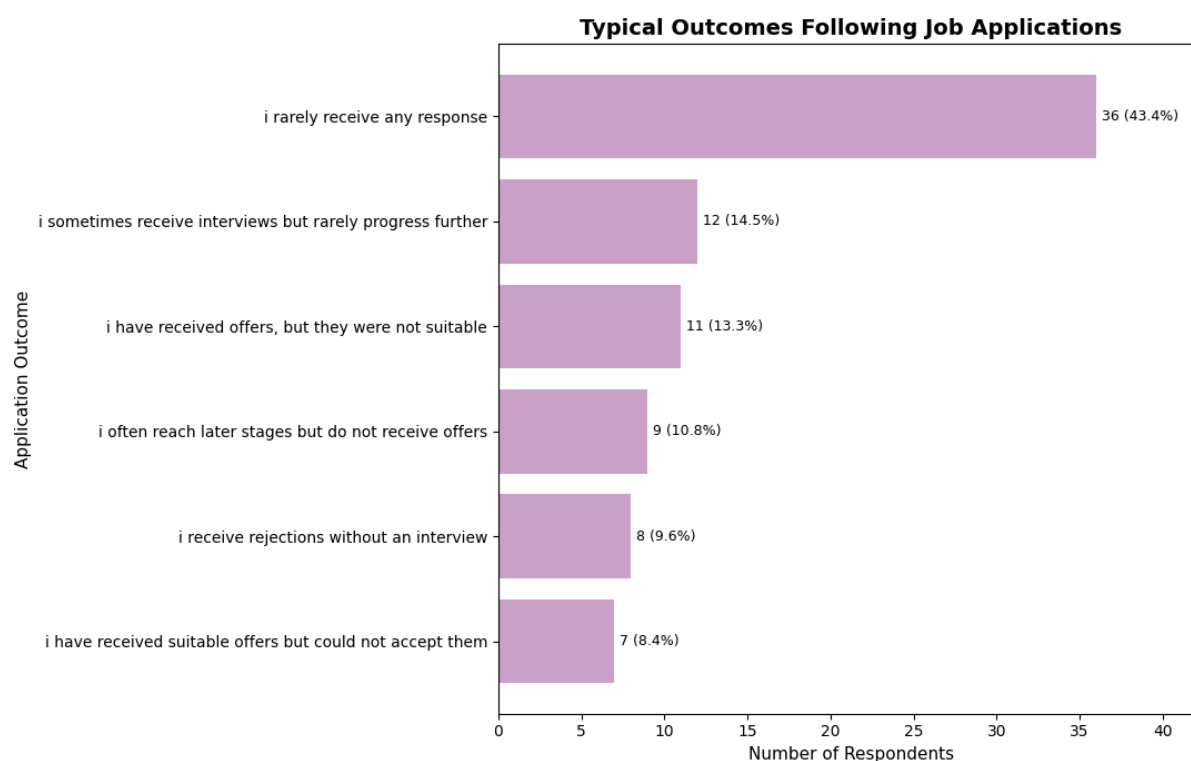


Figure 8: Typical outcomes following job applications.

Figure 8 presents the outcomes experienced by respondents after submitting job applications. The most prominent finding is the high proportion of respondents who rarely receive any response (43.4%), suggesting that limited employer feedback is a major challenge in the application process. Among those who progress further, some receive interviews or reach later recruitment stages without securing an offer, while others receive offers that are unsuitable or cannot be accepted. Overall, the findings suggest that the challenge extends beyond accessing vacancies to converting applications

into meaningful recruitment outcomes, with limited feedback and difficulties progressing through the selection process representing important obstacles to employment.

4.6 Experience, Skills, and Employment Preparation

This section examines the relationship between respondents' education and training and the requirements they encounter when seeking employment.

4.6.1 Experience Requirements

Experience Requirement	Count	Percentage
Very often	29	34.9%
Sometimes	25	30.1%
Often	16	19.3%
Rarely	6	7.2%
Never	6	7.2%
Not sure	1	1.2%

Table 8: Frequency of Encountering Jobs Requiring More Experience Than Youth Possess

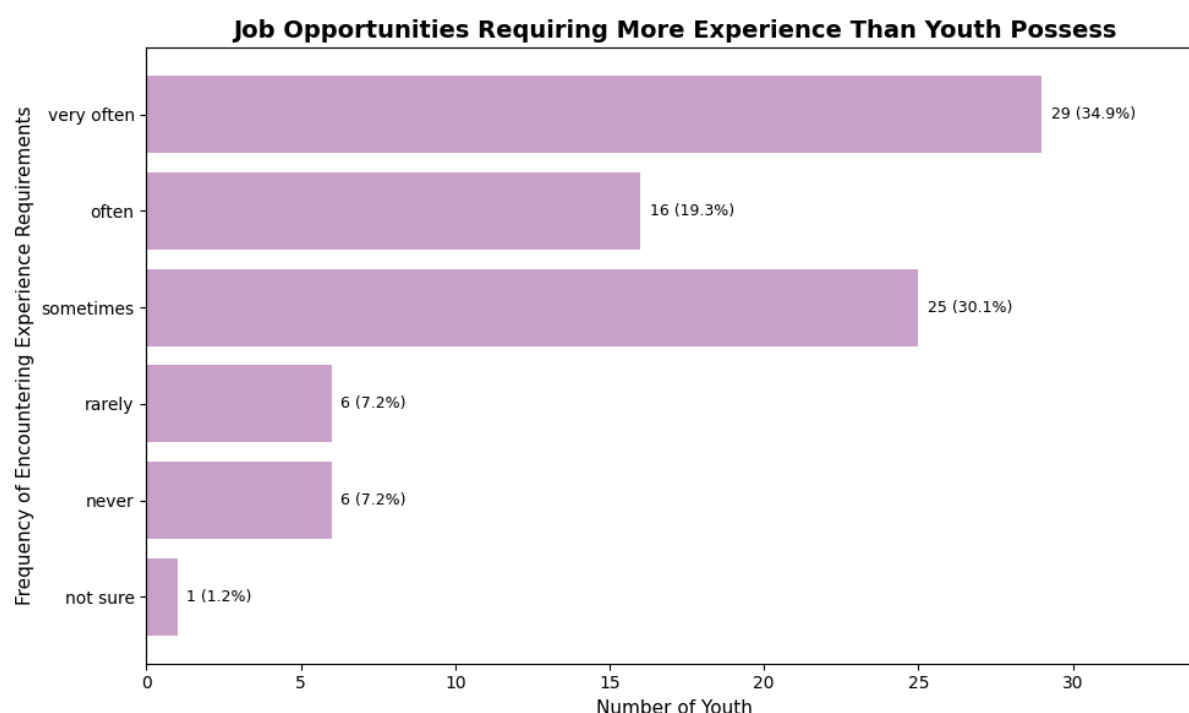


Figure 9: Frequency with which respondents encounter experience requirements beyond their current experience.

Figure 9 presents young job seekers' perceptions of how often available jobs require more experience than they possess. The results indicate that experience requirements are a widespread concern: 84.3% of respondents reported encountering this issue at least sometimes, while 54.2% experience it often or very often. This suggests that lack of practical experience may represent an important barrier to entering the labor market, particularly for young people seeking their first employment opportunities.

The finding is consistent with the earlier results identifying lack of practical work experience as the most frequently reported employment barrier.

4.6.2 Education and Training Preparedness

Education and Training Preparedness	Count	Per-centage
Very well	0	0.0%
Well	0	0.0%
Moderately	31	37.3%
Slightly	15	18.1%
Not at all	6	7.2%
I have not received relevant education or training	5	6.0%

Table 9: Perceived Education and Training Preparedness for Employment

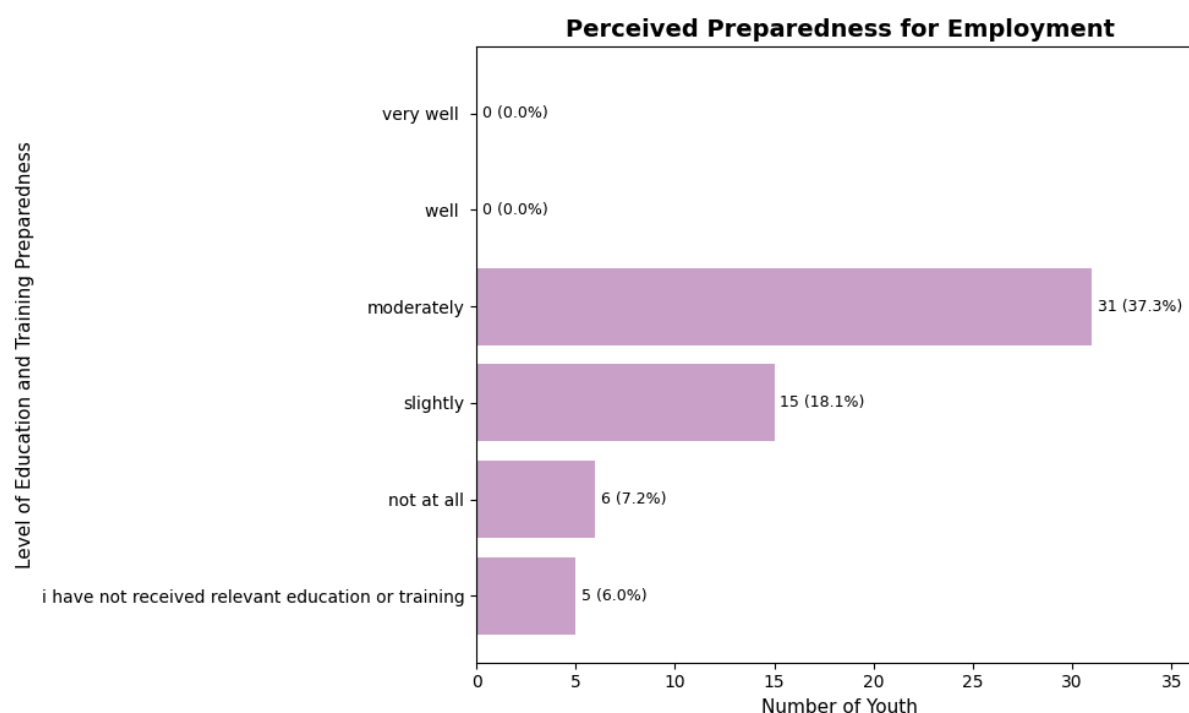


Figure 10: Perceived preparedness for employment.

Figure 10 presents young job seekers' perceptions of how well their university education or training prepared them for employment. The findings indicate that respondents generally perceive their preparation as limited, with 37.3% reporting moderate preparation and 25.3% reporting little or no preparation. Notably, no respondents reported being well or very well prepared. This suggests a perceived gap between formal education or training and the practical requirements of employment, particularly in terms of workplace readiness and relevant experience. The finding is consistent with the earlier results identifying lack of practical work experience as a major barrier to employment.

4.6.3 Missing Skills and Knowledge

Missing Skills and Knowledge	Count	Percentage
Other	5	6.0%
Problem-solving / critical thinking	6	7.2%
Digital skills	8	9.6%
Professional certifications	9	10.8%
Knowledge of the Lebanese job market	12	14.5%
Communication skills	16	19.3%
English or other language skills	19	22.9%
Interview skills	21	25.3%
Technical / job-specific skills	31	37.3%
Practical work experience	32	38.6%

Table 10: Skills and knowledge identified as missing by youth respondents. Multiple responses were permitted; percentages are calculated based on the total sample (N = 83) and therefore do not sum to 100%.

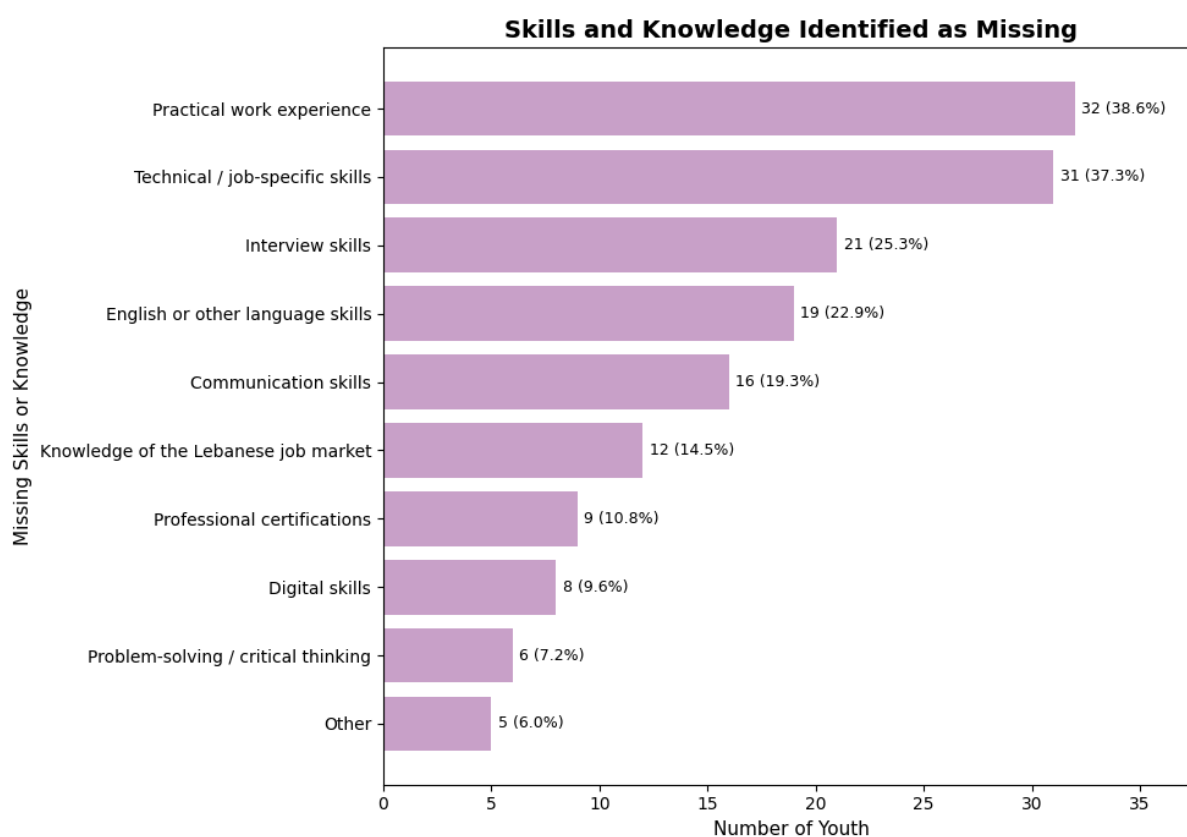


Figure 11: Skills and knowledge identified as missing by respondents.

Figure 11 presents the skills and knowledge that young job seekers identify as missing or insufficient. The results show that the main perceived gaps are practical work experience (38.6%) and technical or job-specific skills (37.3%). Interview, language, and communication skills were also identified by a notable proportion of respondents. Overall, the findings suggest that young job seekers primarily perceive gaps in practical readiness and job-specific competencies, reinforcing the importance of connecting education and training with workplace experience and employer requirements.

4.7 Professional Networks and Recruitment Access

Access to professional connections is examined separately because networking may influence how young people access employment opportunities.

4.7.1 Importance of Professional Connections

Importance of Professional Connections	Count	Percentage
Extremely important	38	45.8%
Very important	27	32.5%
Moderately important	9	10.8%
Slightly important	2	2.4%
Not important at all	2	2.4%
I don't know	5	6.0%

Table 11: Perceived Importance of Personal and Professional Connections in Obtaining Employment
caption: [Perceived Importance of Personal and Professional Connections in Obtaining Employment].)

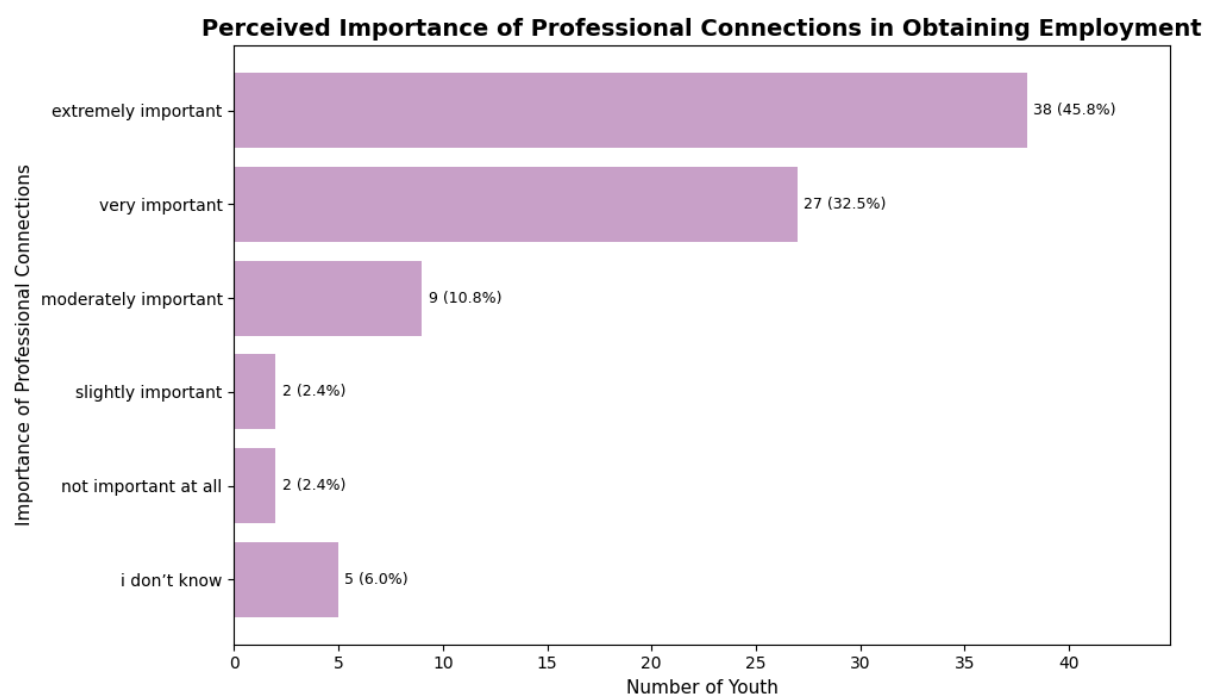


Figure 12: Perceived importance of personal and professional connections in obtaining employment.

Figure 12 presents young job seekers' views on the importance of professional connections in finding employment. The results show that professional connections are perceived as highly important, with 78.3% of respondents rating them as extremely or very important. Only 4.8% considered them slightly important or not important at all, while 6.0% were unsure. Overall, the findings indicate a strong perceived importance of professional connections in young people's access to employment opportunities.

4.7.2 Need for Referrals

Need for Personal Connections or Referrals	Count	Percentage
Yes, frequently	41	49.4%
Yes, sometimes	31	37.3%
Rarely	4	4.8%
Never	4	4.8%
Not sure	3	3.6%

Table 12: Reported need for personal connections or referrals.

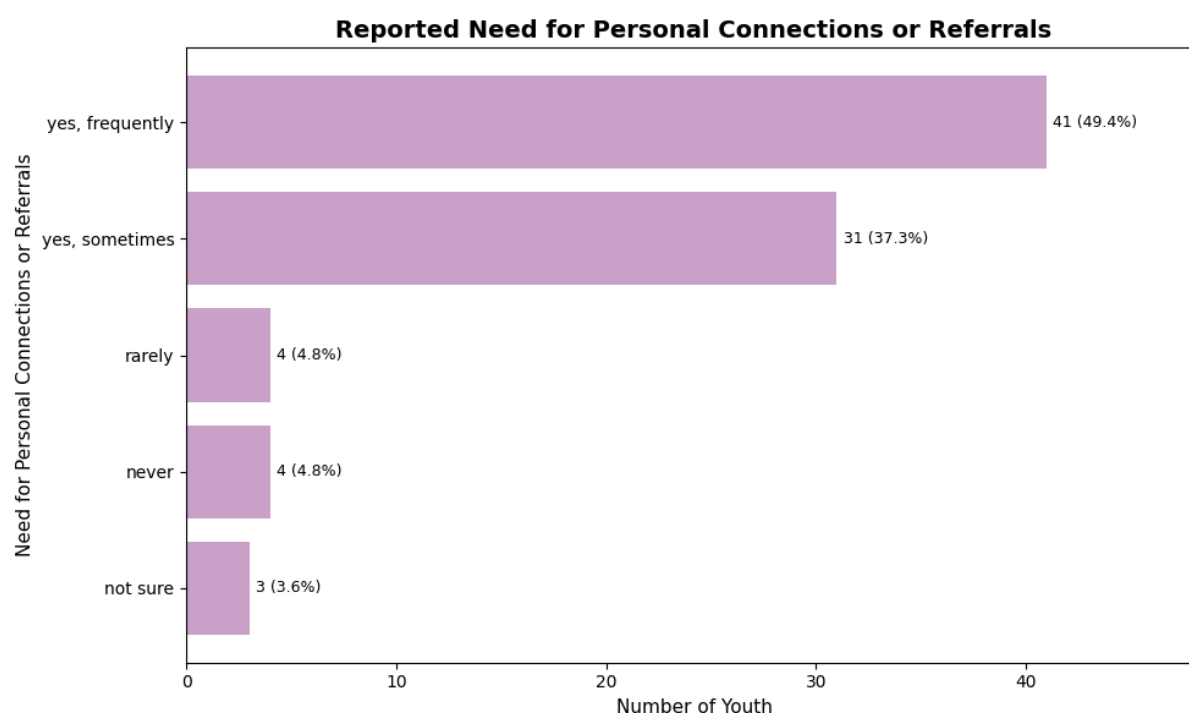


Figure 13: Reported need for personal connections or referrals.

Figure 13 presents how often young job seekers need personal connections or referrals when applying for employment. The results show a strong reliance on connections, with 86.7% of respondents reporting that they need them frequently or sometimes. Only 9.6% reported rarely or never needing connections, while 3.6% were unsure. Overall, the findings indicate that personal connections and referrals are a common part of the employment-search process for young job seekers.

4.7.3 Interview Experience

Interview Experience	Count	Percentage
Never	26	31.3%
2–3 times	18	21.7%
Once	17	20.5%
I have never had a job interview	10	12.0%
More than 5 times	6	7.2%
4–5 times	6	7.2%

Table 13: Frequency of Reaching Job Interviews Without Subsequently Receiving an Offer

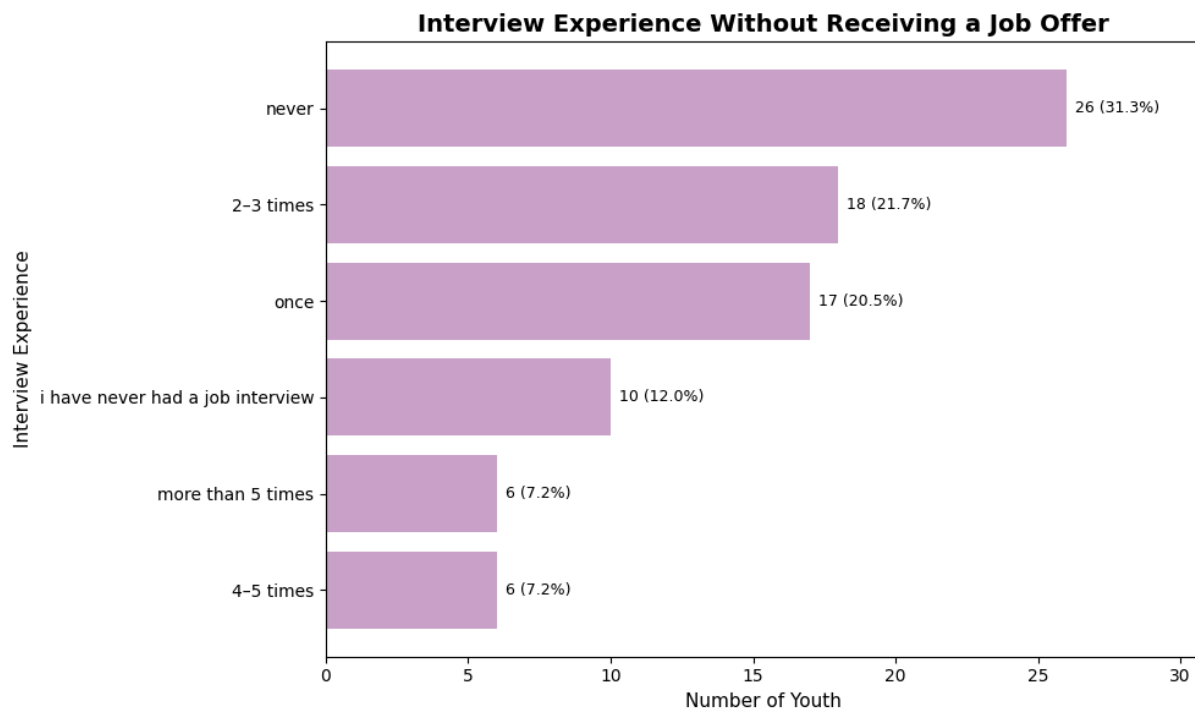


Figure 14: Interview outcomes and difficulties experienced by respondents.

Figure 14 presents respondents' experience of attending job interviews without subsequently receiving a job offer. The results show that 31.3% reported never receiving an offer after an interview, while 49.4% had experienced this situation between one and three times. A further 14.4% reported experiencing it four or more times. Overall, 88.0% of respondents had attended at least one job interview, indicating that most had reached the interview stage, but many experienced repeated interviews without securing an offer. This suggests that progressing from the interview stage to employment remains a challenge for a substantial proportion of young job seekers.

4.7.4 Effects of Repeated Rejection

Effect of Repeated Rejection	Count	Percentage
I continue applying, but with less motivation	33	39.8%
No effect — I continue applying as usual	31	37.3%
I stop applying for jobs for a period of time	8	9.6%
I reduce the number of jobs I apply for	7	8.4%
I stop applying for jobs altogether	4	4.8%

Table 14: Effects of Repeated Job Rejection on Job-Search Behavior

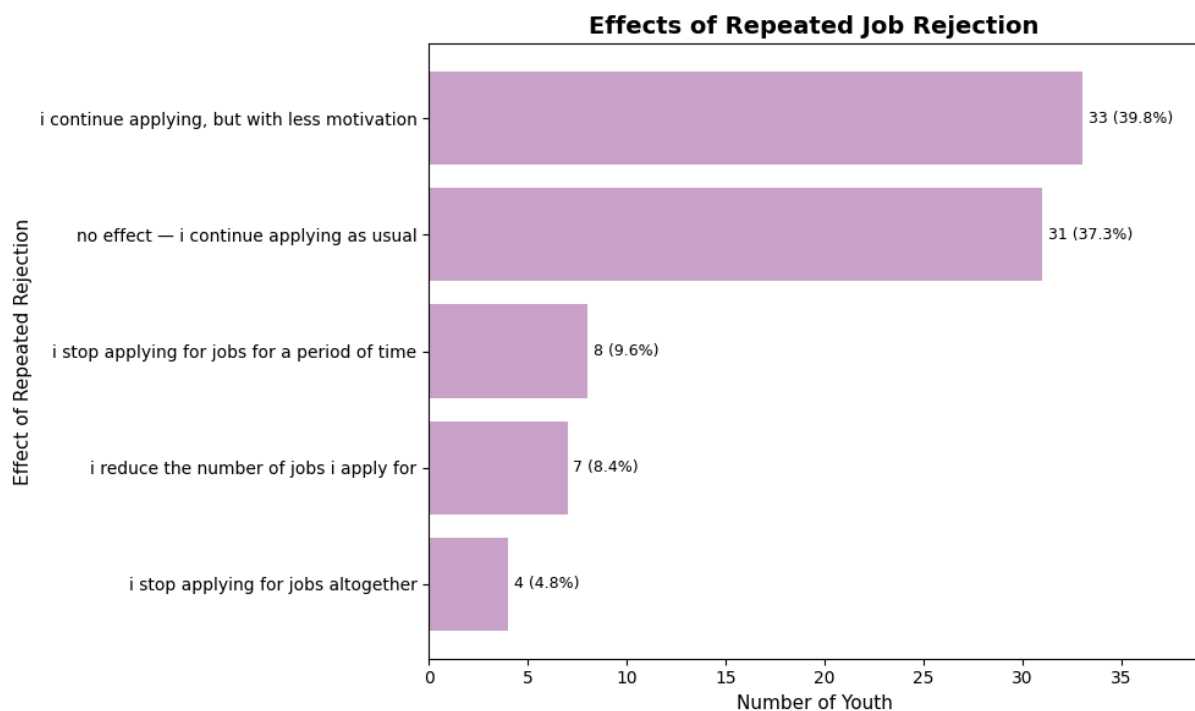


Figure 15: Effects of repeated job rejection on respondents.

Figure 15 presents the effects of repeated job rejection on young job seekers' job-search behaviour. The results show that 62.7% of respondents reported some negative effect, either continuing to apply with less motivation, reducing their applications, temporarily stopping, or stopping altogether. In contrast, 37.3% reported no effect and continued applying as usual. Overall, the findings indicate that repeated rejection can affect the persistence and motivation of a substantial proportion of young job seekers, while a considerable group remains persistent in their job search.

4.7.5 Employer Feedback

Employer Feedback	Count	Percentage
I usually do not receive a response	25	30.1%
Almost never	23	27.7%
Rarely	18	21.7%
Sometimes	12	14.5%
Often	5	6.0%

Table 15: Frequency of Receiving Employer Feedback Following Unsuccessful Applications

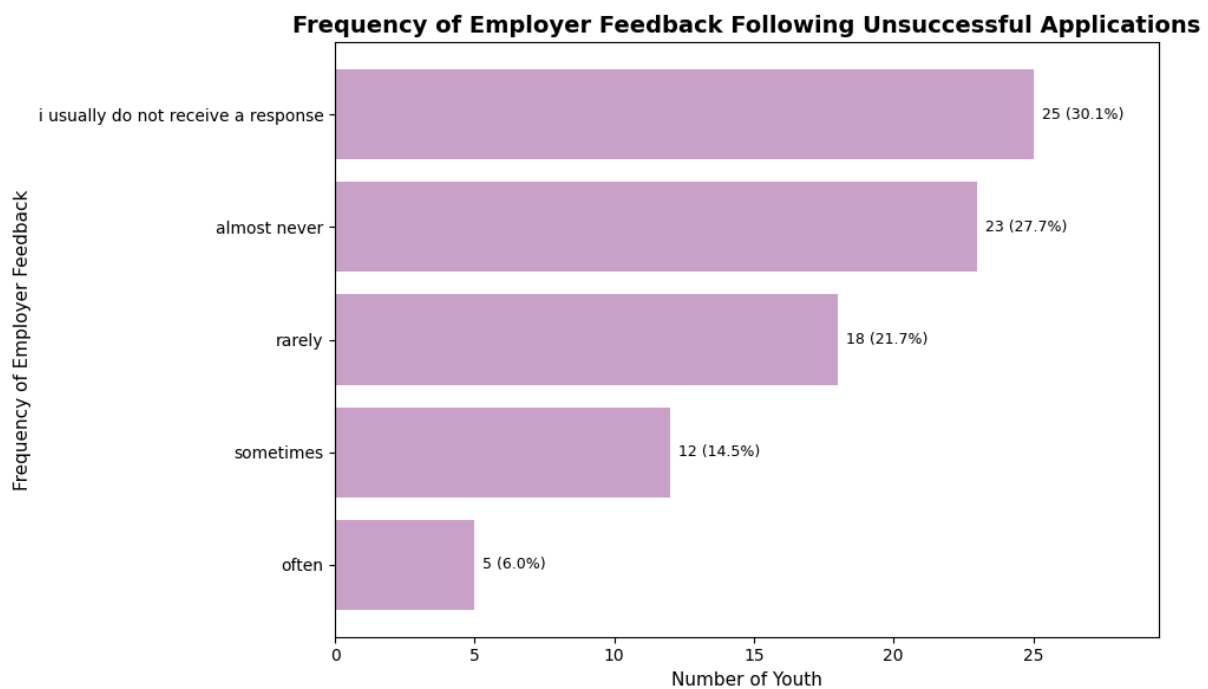


Figure 16: Frequency of employer feedback following unsuccessful applications.

Figure 16 presents the frequency with which young job seekers receive employer feedback following unsuccessful applications. The results show that 79.5% of respondents receive feedback rarely, almost never, or usually not at all. Only 20.5% reported receiving feedback sometimes or often. Overall, the findings indicate that employer feedback is limited for most young job seekers, suggesting that communication following unsuccessful applications remains a significant gap in the recruitment process.

4.8 Structural Conditions and Job Quality

This section examines broader conditions that influence employment decisions and the sustainability of employment.

4.8.1 Factors Affecting Job Acceptance

Factors Affecting Job Acceptance	Count	Per-centage
Other	4	4.8%
Lack of job security	11	13.3%
Lack of career progression	14	16.9%
Job responsibilities do not match my qualifications or career goals	15	18.1%
Long commuting distance	15	18.1%
Lack of benefits	16	19.3%
Lack of remote or hybrid options	17	20.5%
Poor working conditions	18	21.7%
Long working hours	24	28.9%
Lack of training or learning opportunities	25	30.1%
Salary does not cover basic living costs	42	50.6%
Low salary	44	53.0%

Table 16: Factors Affecting Respondents' Willingness to Accept Employment.

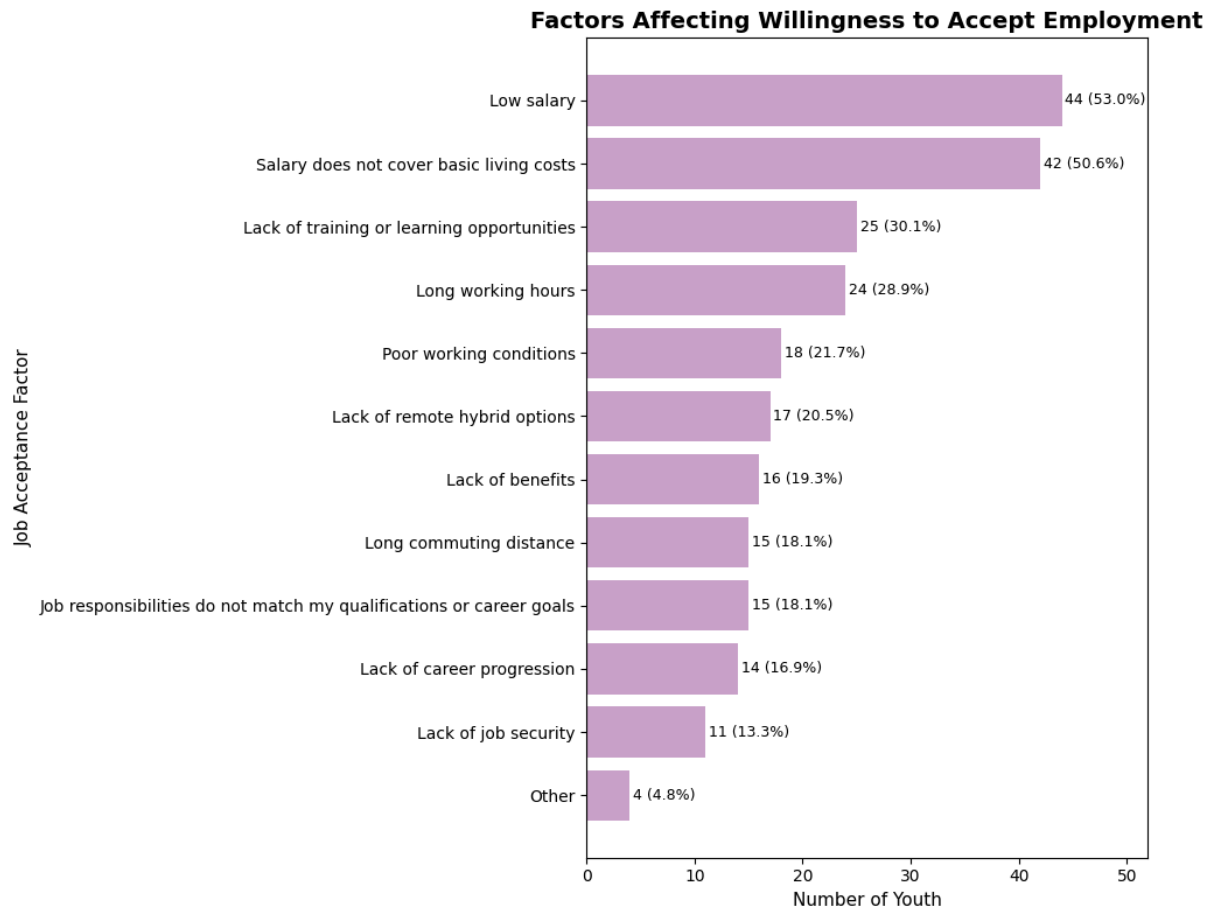


Figure 17: Factors affecting respondents' willingness to accept employment.

Figure 17 presents the factors that may influence young respondents' willingness to accept employment. The most frequently reported factors were low salary (53.0%) and salary that does not cover basic living costs (50.6%), indicating that financial considerations are the dominant factors in job acceptance decisions. This was followed by lack of training or learning opportunities (30.1%) and long working hours (28.9%), while poor working conditions, lack of remote or hybrid options, and lack of benefits were also reported by a notable proportion of respondents. Overall, the findings indicate that respondents evaluate employment opportunities not only based on financial compensation but also on professional development, working conditions, flexibility, and long-term employment value. Since multiple responses were permitted, percentages represent the proportion of respondents identifying each factor and should not be summed.

4.8.2 Responses to Insufficient Salary

Response to Insufficient Salary	Count	Percentage
Accept the job temporarily	28	33.7%
Continue searching for a better-paying job	20	24.1%
Work two or more jobs	14	16.9%
Negotiate for a higher salary or better benefits	7	8.4%
Consider working abroad or emigrating	5	6.0%
Rely on family support while searching	4	4.8%
Turn to freelancing or online work	3	3.6%
Leave the labour market temporarily	2	2.4%

Table 17: Responses to Employment Opportunities with Insufficient Salary.

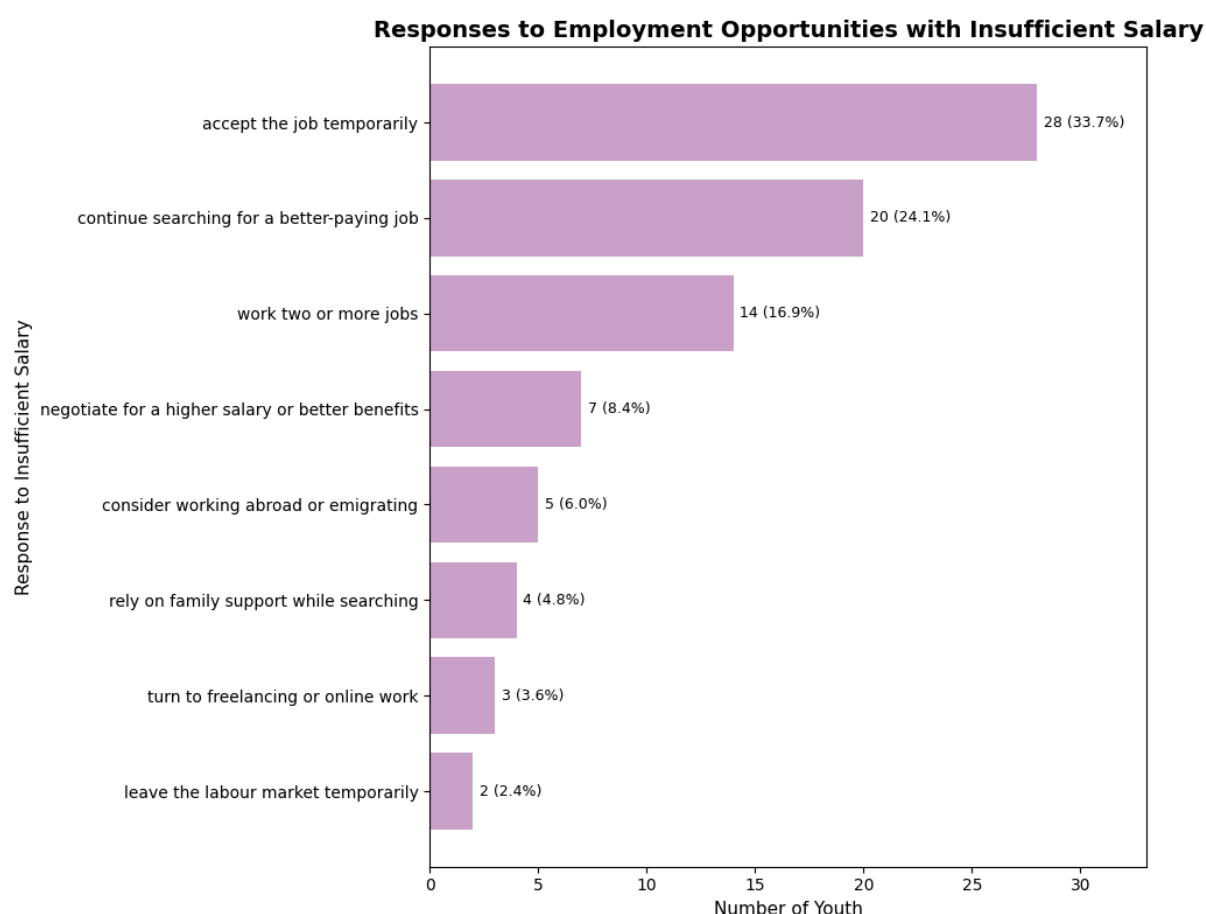


Figure 18: Responses to employment opportunities with insufficient salary.

Figure 18 presents how young respondents would respond to an employment opportunity with an insufficient salary. The most common response was to accept the job temporarily (33.7%), followed by continuing to search for a better-paying job (24.1%) and working two or more jobs (16.9%). Smaller proportions would negotiate for better compensation (8.4%), consider working abroad (6.0%), or rely on

family support while searching (4.8%). Overall, the findings indicate that insufficient salaries may lead respondents to adopt short-term strategies such as temporary acceptance, continued job searching, or combining multiple jobs, while a smaller proportion would consider alternative employment or leaving the labor market temporarily.

4.9 Support and Potential Solutions

The final part of the respondent profile examines what types of support young people believe would most improve their employment prospects.

4.9.1 Most Valuable Forms of Support

Most Valuable Forms of Employment Support	Count	Per-centage
Paid internship practical work experience	54	65.1%
Technical job-specific skills training	23	27.7%
Networking opportunities with employers	17	20.5%
CV application support	14	16.9%
English language training	14	16.9%
Interview preparation	14	16.9%
Digital skills training	13	15.7%
Transportation support	13	15.7%
Mentorship from professionals	9	10.8%
Career guidance	8	9.6%
Apprenticeships workplace training	7	8.4%
Professional certifications	6	7.2%
Financial support during job searching	6	7.2%
Soft skills training	6	7.2%
Job matching services	4	4.8%
Entrepreneurship support	3	3.6%

Table 18: Forms of Employment Support Considered Most Valuable by Respondents

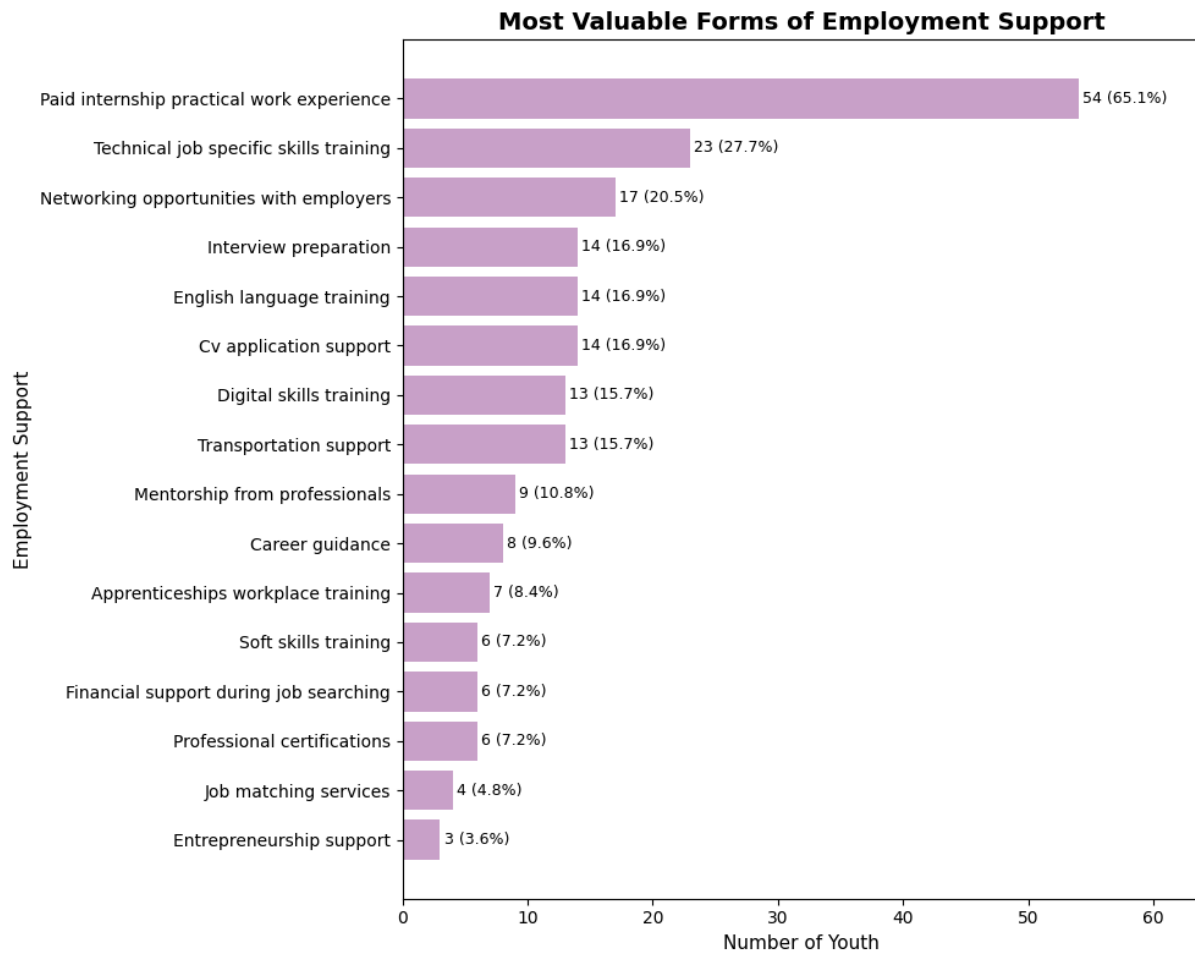


Figure 19: Forms of support considered most useful by graduate job seekers. Multi-answer question.

Figure 19 presents the forms of employment support that young respondents consider most valuable. The most preferred form of support was paid internships or practical work experience (65.1%), followed by technical or job-specific skills training (27.7%) and networking opportunities with employers (20.5%). Other forms of support, including CV and application support, language training, interview preparation, transportation, and digital-skills training, were selected by smaller proportions of respondents. Overall, the findings indicate that young job seekers place the greatest value on direct practical experience and workplace exposure, rather than support focused solely on guidance or classroom-based training. Since multiple responses were permitted, percentages represent the proportion of respondents selecting each option and therefore do not sum to 100%.

4.9.2 Most Valuable Employment Service

Most Valuable Employment Service	Count	Percentage
Paid internship or work experience	48	57.8%
Career guidance and job matching	6	7.2%
English / language training	6	7.2%
Networking directly with employers	5	6.0%
Freelancing / remote-work training	4	4.8%
Job-specific skills training	3	3.6%
Other	3	3.6%
Professional certification	3	3.6%
Entrepreneurship support	2	2.4%
Interview preparation	2	2.4%
Mentorship	1	1.2%

Table 19: Employment Service Considered Most Valuable by Respondents

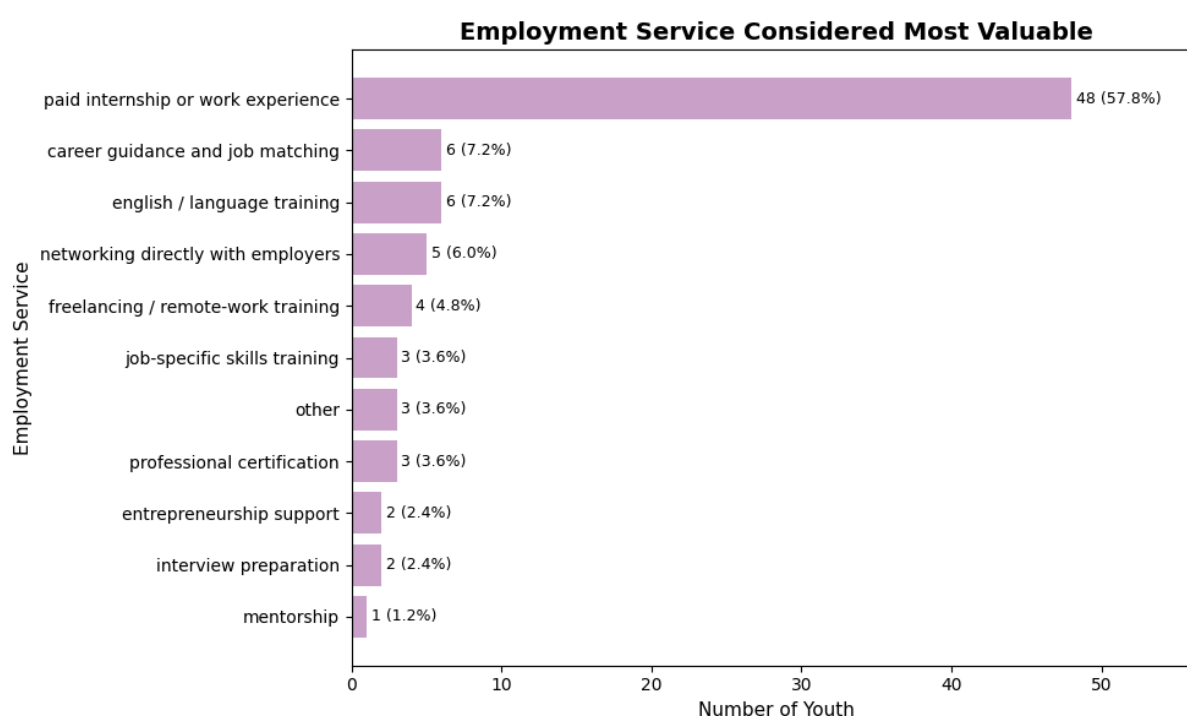


Figure 20: Employment service considered most valuable by respondents.

Figure 20 presents the employment service that young respondents consider most valuable. The results show a clear preference for paid internships or work experience (57.8%), far exceeding any other service. Career guidance, job matching, language training, and employer networking were each selected by fewer than 8% of respondents, while the remaining services received even lower levels of

preference. Overall, the findings indicate that practical workplace experience is the strongest priority among young respondents when considering employment support. Since each respondent selected one most valuable service, the categories are mutually exclusive, with percentages totaling approximately 100% due to rounding.

4.10 Youth Perspectives on Employment Challenges and Solutions

Young respondents primarily emphasized practical access to employment. Paid internships or practical work experience were the most frequently selected form of support (65.1%), and paid internships or work experience were also identified as the most valuable employment service (57.8%). Technical or job-specific training, employer networking, application support, language training, interview preparation, and transportation support were also identified as relevant forms of assistance. These responses provide the youth-side basis for comparing support priorities with the solutions identified by employers.

5 Profile of Employers

This section presents the characteristics and perspectives of the employers included in the study. Understanding employers is essential for identifying the demand side of the labor market and determining what organizations expect from young candidates.

5.1 Recruitment Practices

Recruitment Source	Count	Percentage
LinkedIn	24	66.7%
Employee Referrals	16	44.4%
Direct Applications	14	38.9%
Personal or Professional Networks	13	36.1%
Social Media	13	36.1%
Public Job Postings / Job Platforms	12	33.3%
Universities / Career Offices	11	30.6%
Internships / Previous Interns	5	13.9%
Recommendations from Professors / Teachers	4	11.1%
Recruitment Agencies	3	8.3%

Table 20: Recruitment channels used by surveyed employers. Multiple responses were permitted; percentages represent the proportion of employers selecting each channel and therefore do not sum to 100%.

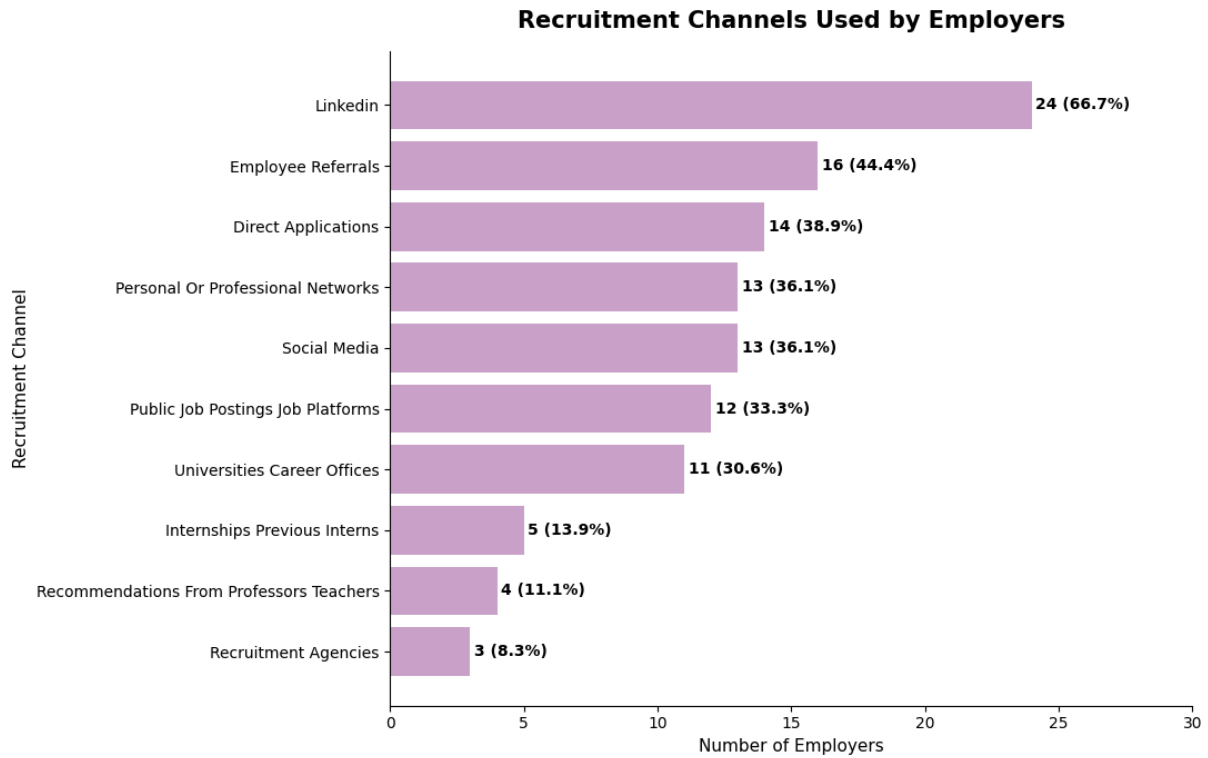


Figure 21: Recruitment channels used by employers.

Figure 21 presents the recruitment channels used by the surveyed employers. LinkedIn was the most widely used channel, reported by 24 employers (66.7%), followed by employee referrals (44.4%) and direct applications (38.9%). Personal or professional networks and social media were each used by 36.1% of employers, while public job postings/job platforms and university career offices were also relatively common, at 33.3% and 30.6%, respectively. In contrast, internships or previous interns (13.9%), recommendations from professors or teachers (11.1%), and recruitment agencies (8.3%) were used less frequently. Overall, the findings indicate that employers rely predominantly on digital and network-based recruitment channels, particularly LinkedIn and employee referrals, while formal intermediary channels such as recruitment agencies play a smaller role.

5.2 What Employers Look For

Factor	Count	Percentage
Communication Skills	21	58.3%
Technical / Job-Specific Skills	20	55.6%
Problem-Solving Ability	12	33.3%
Education / Degree	10	27.8%
Motivation	10	27.8%
Ability to Learn / Adaptability	9	25.0%
Previous Work Experience	6	16.7%
Practical Projects / Portfolio	4	11.1%
Professionalism	4	11.1%
Referral / Recommendation	3	8.3%
Internship Experience	3	8.3%
English Language Skills	2	5.6%
Availability / Flexibility	1	2.8%
Professional Network	1	2.8%
Salary Expectations	1	2.8%
University Attended	1	2.8%

Table 21: Factors considered by employers when evaluating young candidates. Multiple responses were permitted; percentages represent the proportion of employers selecting each factor and therefore do not sum to 100%.

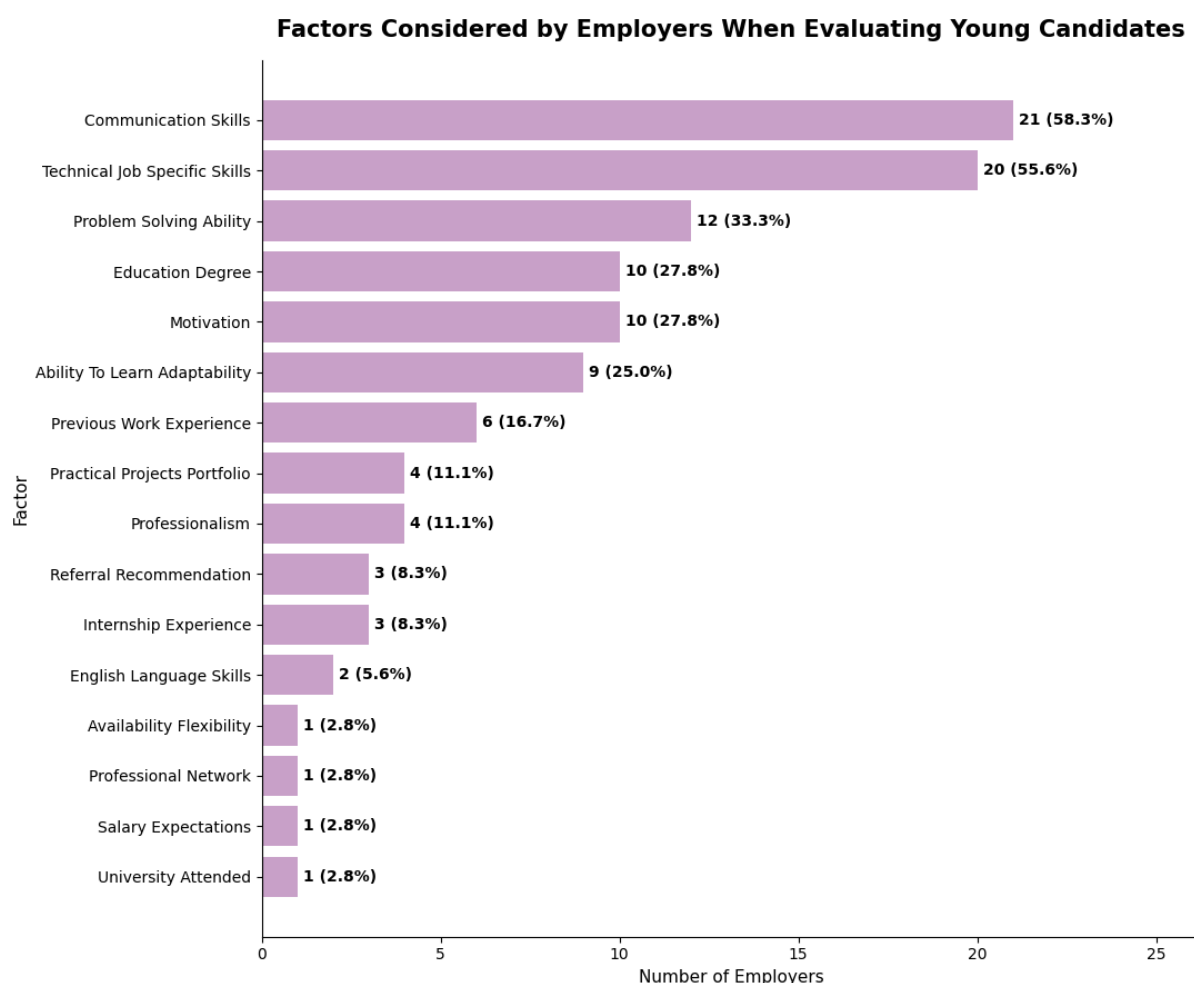


Figure 22: Factors considered by employers when evaluating young candidates.

Figure 22 presents the factors employers consider when evaluating young candidates. Communication skills (58.3%) and technical or job-specific skills (55.6%) were the most frequently selected factors, followed by problem-solving ability (33.3%). Education and degree and motivation were each reported by 27.8% of employers, while ability to learn and adapt was identified by 25.0%. Previous work experience (16.7%), practical projects or portfolios (11.1%), and professionalism (11.1%) were selected less frequently, while referrals, internship experience, English language skills, availability, professional networks, salary expectations, and university attended were reported by fewer employers. Overall, the findings indicate that employers in the sample place greater emphasis on communication, technical competence, and problem-solving ability than on formal educational credentials or university attended when evaluating young candidates.

5.2.1 Importance Ratings

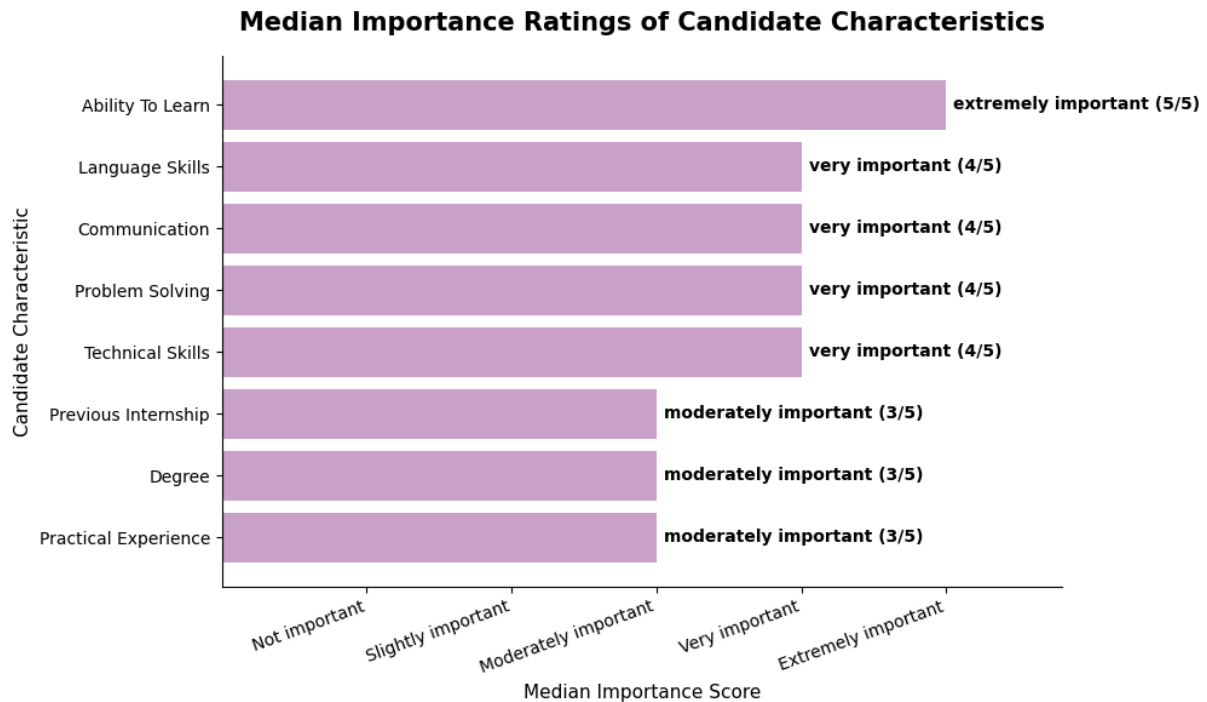


Figure 23: Employer ratings of candidate characteristics.

The median importance ratings indicate that employers generally place a high level of importance on the characteristics assessed. Ability to learn and adaptability received the highest median rating of **extremely important**. Communication skills, technical skills, problem-solving ability, and language skills were rated **very important**, indicating that employers place substantial emphasis on both technical competencies and broader workplace capabilities. In contrast, practical experience, degree, and previous internship experience had a median rating of **moderately important**. Overall, the findings suggest that employers place greater emphasis on candidates' capabilities, particularly adaptability, communication, technical skills, and problem-solving, than on formal educational credentials or previous internship experience.

5.3 Why Young Candidates Are Rejected

Reason for Non-Selection	Count	Percentage
Weak Communication Skills	18	50.0%
Insufficient Technical / Job-Specific Skills	16	44.4%
Lack of Practical Experience	14	38.9%
Lack of Professionalism	10	27.8%
Poor Interview Performance	9	25.0%
Lack of Motivation	7	19.4%
Education Does Not Match Position	6	16.7%
Weak English Language Skills	6	16.7%
Lack of Previous Work Experience	6	16.7%
Salary Expectations	4	11.1%
Lack of Long-Term Commitment	3	8.3%
Location / Transportation	3	8.3%
Employer Needed a More Experienced Candidate	2	5.6%
Availability / Working Hours	2	5.6%
No Relevant Portfolio / Projects	2	5.6%

Table 22: Reasons reported by employers for not selecting young candidates. Multiple responses were permitted; percentages represent the proportion of employers selecting each reason and therefore do not sum to 100%.

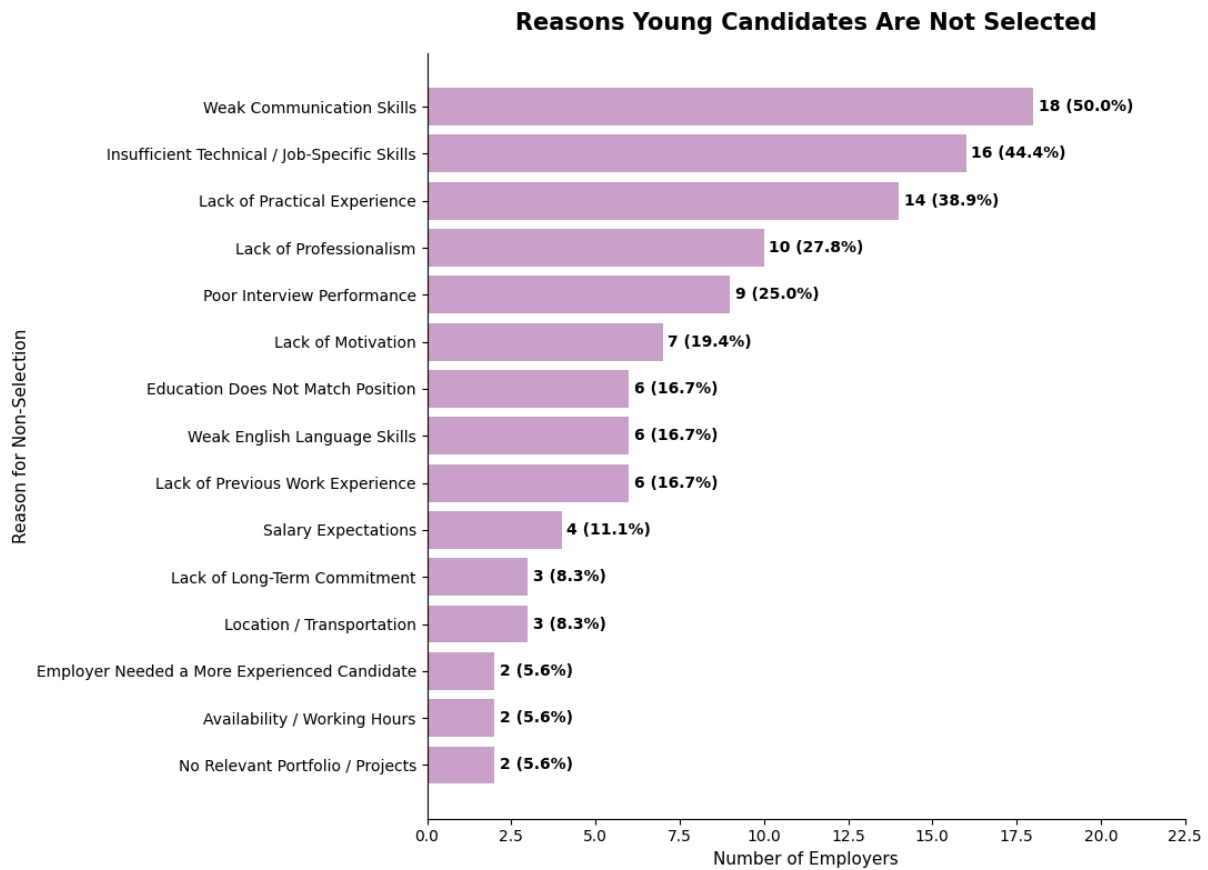


Figure 24: Reasons young candidates are not selected.

The results show that employers most frequently reported weak communication skills as a reason for not selecting young candidates, identified by 50.0% of employers. This was followed by insufficient technical or job-specific skills (44.4%) and lack of practical experience (38.9%), indicating that communication, technical competence, and practical readiness are the most prominent reported reasons for non-selection. Lack of professionalism (27.8%) and poor interview performance (25.0%) were also notable, while formal education mismatch, weak English skills, and lack of previous work experience were each reported by 16.7% of employers. Overall, the findings indicate that employers' reported rejection reasons are concentrated more strongly around workplace competencies, practical readiness, and communication than around formal educational qualifications alone.

5.4 Employer Hiring Barriers

Hiring Challenge	Count	Percentage
Many Applicants but Few Met Requirements	25	69.4%
Candidates Lacked the Experience We Expected	18	50.0%
Candidates Lacked the Skills We Needed	16	44.4%
Candidates Expected Higher Salaries Than We Could Offer	16	44.4%
Suitable Candidates Declined Our Offers	11	30.6%
Candidates Unavailable Due to Location / Transportation / Working Hours	9	25.0%
Suitable Candidates Accepted but Later Left	5	13.9%
Too Few Applicants	2	5.6%

Table 23: Challenges experienced by surveyed employers when hiring young people. Multiple responses were permitted; percentages represent the proportion of employers selecting each challenge and therefore do not sum to 100%.

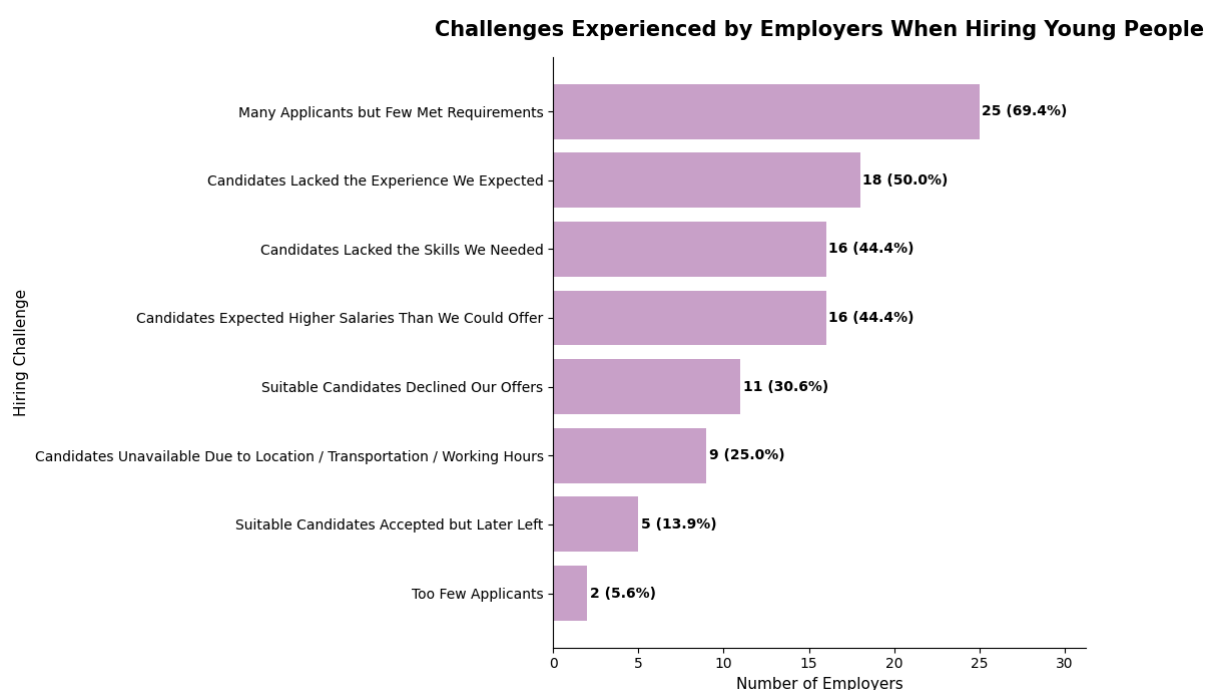


Figure 25: Challenges experienced by employers when hiring young people.

The results indicate that employers face difficulties primarily with candidate quality rather than a lack of applicants. The most frequently reported challenge is receiving many applicants but finding few who meet the required criteria (69.4%). This is followed by candidates lacking the expected experience (50.0%) and candidates lacking the required skills (44.4%). Salary expectations were also reported by 44.4% of employers, while candidate availability, offer rejection, and subsequent turnover were less frequently reported. Overall, the findings suggest that employer-side hiring barriers are concentrated around the alignment between candidate qualifications, experience, skills, and employer expectations, rather than simply the availability of applicants.

5.5 Employer Expectations and Practices

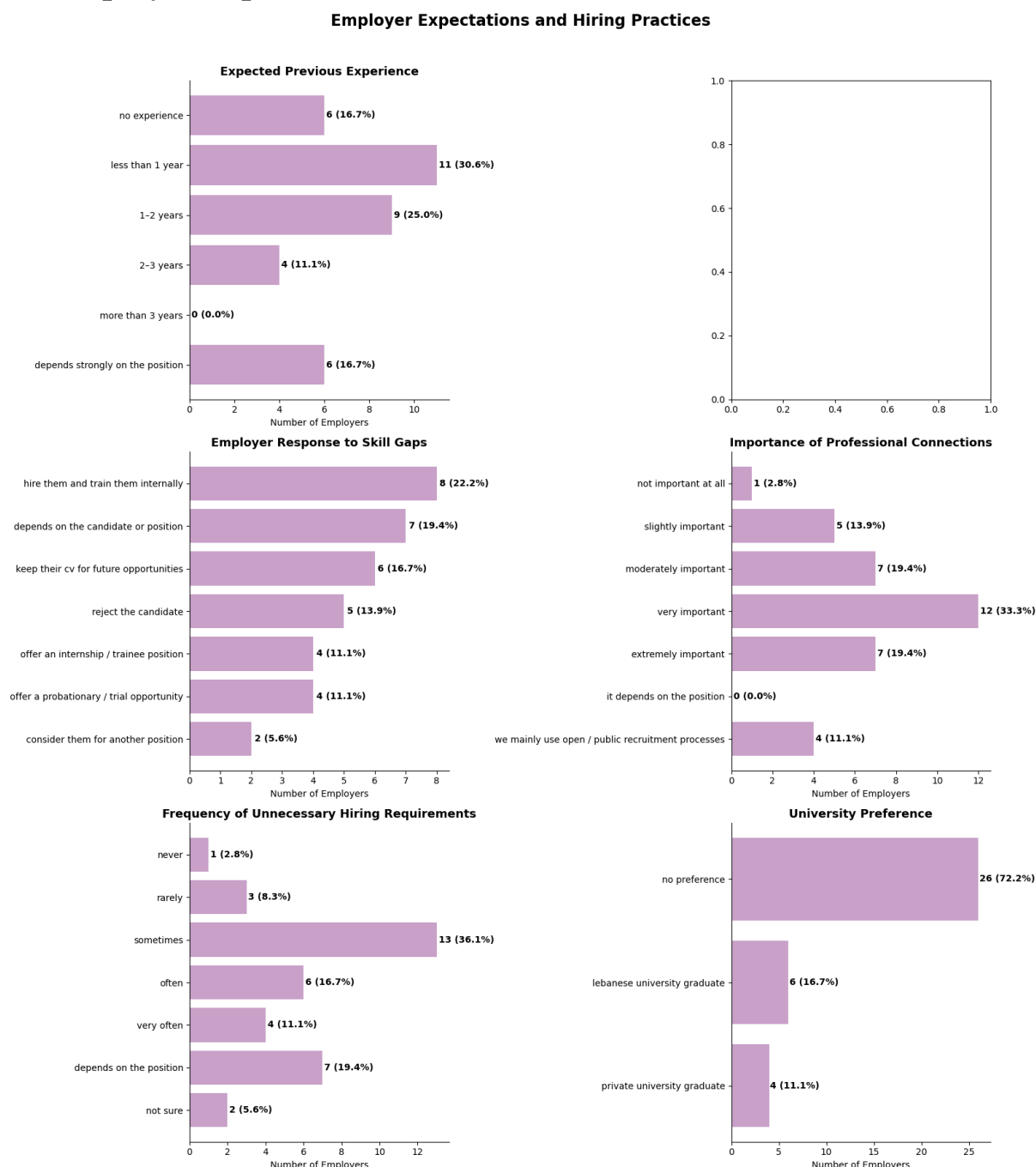


Figure 26: Selected employer expectations and hiring practices.

The results show that employers generally expect some level of previous experience when hiring young people. The median expectation is 1–2 years of experience, although 11 employers reported that less than one year was sufficient and 6 reported that no previous experience was required, while expectations also depended strongly on the position for 6 employers. Professional connections were also considered important, with a median rating of very important, indicating that networks may play a significant role in recruitment. In addition, the median response regarding unnecessary hiring requirements was often, suggesting that employers frequently recognize the presence of requirements that may not always be essential to the position. When candidates lack required skills, employers showed varied responses, with internal training being the most common approach (8 employers), followed by decisions that depend on the candidate or position (7) and retaining candidates' CVs

for future opportunities (6). Finally, university preference was limited, as 26 of 36 employers (72.2%) reported no preference, compared with 6 preferring Lebanese University graduates and 4 preferring private university graduates.

5.6 Employer Perspectives on Solutions

Practical Solution	Count	Percentage
Better Salaries / Compensation	15	41.7%
Career Guidance	13	36.1%
Internships / Apprenticeships	11	30.6%
University / Employer Partnerships	10	27.8%
Job-Specific Training	9	25.0%
Mentorship	9	25.0%
Professional Networking Opportunities	8	22.2%
Better Working Conditions	5	13.9%
Interview Preparation	5	13.9%
Job Placement / Job Matching	5	13.9%
Employer-Linked Training	3	8.3%
Government Incentives for Employers	3	8.3%
Entrepreneurship Support	2	5.6%

Table 24: Practical solutions selected by surveyed employers. Multiple responses were permitted; percentages represent the proportion of employers selecting each solution and therefore do not sum to 100%.

The results indicate that employers prioritize financial and career-development measures when identifying practical solutions to improve youth employment. Better salaries and compensation were the most frequently selected solution (41.7%), followed by career guidance (36.1%) and internships or apprenticeships (30.6%). University–employer partnerships (27.8%), job-specific training (25.0%), and mentorship (25.0%) were also selected by substantial proportions of employers, highlighting the importance of stronger links between education, workplace exposure, and career development. In contrast, government incentives (8.3%) and entrepreneurship support (5.6%) were less frequently selected. Overall, the findings suggest that employers favor solutions that directly improve employment conditions, career preparation, practical experience, and connections between young people and the labor market. Since multiple responses were permitted, percentages represent the proportion of employers selecting each solution and therefore do not sum to 100%.

6 Youth–Employer Comparison

This section brings the two perspectives together by comparing related dimensions identified in the separate youth and employer analyses. The comparison focuses on areas where youth respondents report barriers or gaps and where employers report corresponding requirements, recruitment practices, or potential solutions. The comparison is primarily descriptive and is used to identify areas of apparent alignment and divergence between the two perspectives.

6.1 Mapping the Two Perspectives

Youth Perspective	Employer Perspective	Common Dimension
43.4% of youth identified lack of practical work experience as an employment barrier	80.5% of employers rated practical experience as at least moderately important	Practical experience
10.8% of youth reported lacking technical skills as an employment barrier	82.9% of employers rated technical skills as at least moderately important	Technical skills
19.3% of youth reported missing communication skills, while 7.2% reported missing problem-solving skills	91.7% of employers rated communication and 89.0% rated problem-solving as at least moderately important	Workplace soft skills
89.1% of youth rated personal or professional connections as at least moderately important	72.1% of employers rated personal or professional connections as at least moderately important	Professional networks and access
9.6% of youth identified career guidance as a solution	36.1% of employers identified career guidance as a solution	Career guidance
65.1% of youth identified paid internships as a solution, while 57.8% identified paid internships or work experience as the most valuable support	30.6% of employers identified internships as a potential solution	Internships and practical work experience
27.7% of youth identified technical or job-specific training as a solution	25.0% of employers identified job-specific training as a potential solution	Job-specific training
20.5% of youth identified networking opportunities with employers as a solution	22.2% of employers identified networking with employers as a potential solution	Employer networking opportunities

6.2 Areas of Alignment

The comparison reveals several areas in which the perspectives of unemployed youth and employers converge. These areas suggest that at least some of the difficulties experienced by young job seekers correspond to requirements or solutions identified by employers.

Finding: 43.4% of youth identified lack of practical work experience as an employment barrier, while 80.5% of employers rated practical experience as at least moderately important.

Employer perspective: Employers therefore place substantial importance on candidates' practical exposure to the workplace.

Interpretation: This represents a clear alignment around practical experience. Both perspectives point to workplace exposure as an important dimension of youth employability, suggesting that limited practical experience may contribute to difficulties in the transition from education to employment.

Finding: 10.8% of youth reported lacking technical skills as an employment barrier, while 82.9% of employers rated technical skills as at least moderately important.

Employer perspective: Technical skills are among the most strongly emphasized attributes in employer hiring expectations.

Interpretation: The two perspectives are aligned on the relevance of technical skills, although the strength of emphasis differs considerably. The relatively small proportion of youth identifying technical skills as a barrier compared with the high importance assigned by employers suggests a potential perception or preparedness gap that warrants further attention.

Finding: 20.5% of youth identified networking opportunities with employers as a potential solution, compared with 22.2% of employers.

Employer perspective: Employers also identified professional networking opportunities as a practical solution for improving youth employment.

Interpretation: The close percentages indicate strong convergence around the value of connecting young people directly with employers. This suggests that employer networking could be a mutually recognized mechanism for improving access to employment opportunities.

Finding: 27.7% of youth identified technical or job-specific training as a solution, compared with 25.0% of employers.

Employer perspective: Employers similarly identified job-specific training as a practical intervention.

Interpretation: This is one of the strongest areas of convergence in the solutions analysis. Both groups recognize the value of training that is directly connected to workplace and job requirements, supporting the development of employment-oriented training programs.

Overall, these areas of alignment indicate that youth and employers share several important views regarding employability and potential interventions. In particular, practical experience, job-specific training, and direct connections with employers emerge as common themes. However, the differences in the magnitude of the reported percentages indicate that convergence in topic does not necessarily imply convergence in the strength of the perceived problem.

6.3 Areas of Mismatch

Despite several areas of convergence, the comparison also reveals important differences between how unemployed youth perceive their employment needs and how employers view the requirements and solutions associated with youth employment. These mismatches are particularly evident in career guidance, practical workplace experience, and workplace soft skills.

Finding: Only 9.6% of youth identified career guidance as a solution, compared with 36.1% of employers.

Employer perspective: Career guidance was one of the most frequently selected solutions by employers.

Interpretation: This difference suggests that employers may perceive a greater need for career guidance than young job seekers themselves. Youth may prioritize direct access to employment and practical experience, whereas employers may place greater value on helping young people understand career pathways, job expectations, and how to prepare for employment.

Finding: 65.1% of youth identified paid internships as a solution, while 30.6% of employers identified internships or apprenticeships as a potential solution.

Employer perspective: Employers recognize internships as a solution, but place considerably less emphasis on them than youth.

Interpretation: This represents a substantial difference in intervention priorities. Young people strongly favor direct workplace exposure, particularly through paid internships, whereas employers are less likely to prioritize internships at the same level. The difference may reflect the immediate employment needs of youth and the differing costs, responsibilities, or expectations associated with providing internship opportunities from the employer perspective.

Finding: Employers place very high importance on communication and problem-solving skills, with 91.7% and 89.0% respectively rating them as at least moderately important. In contrast, 19.3% of youth reported missing communication skills and 7.2% reported missing problem-solving skills.

Employer perspective: Communication and problem-solving are among the most widely valued workplace competencies.

Interpretation: The comparison suggests a potential perception or measurement gap between employers and youth. Employers emphasize these competencies strongly, while relatively few youth identify them as missing. This does not necessarily mean that youth lack these skills; rather, it may indicate differences in how young people assess their own competencies and how employers evaluate them during recruitment.

Finding: 89.1% of youth rated personal or professional connections as at least moderately important, compared with 72.1% of employers.

Employer perspective: Employers also recognize the importance of professional connections, but to a lesser extent than youth.

Interpretation: This difference suggests that young people may perceive access to professional networks as a more significant determinant of employment opportunities than employers do. The finding is particularly relevant because limited access to professional networks can affect a young person's ability to discover vacancies, obtain referrals, and reach employers.

Overall, the mismatches indicate that the two groups do not necessarily prioritize the same interventions or perceive employability challenges with the same intensity. Youth place greater emphasis on direct workplace access and internships, while employers place greater emphasis on career guidance and workplace competencies. These differences are important for designing interventions because solutions based exclusively on either the youth or employer perspective may fail to address the priorities of the other side.

7 From Gaps to Solutions

The preceding analysis identified areas of alignment and mismatch between unemployed youth and employers. Rather than repeating these findings, this section translates them into an integrated intervention framework. The objective is to address the employment transition from both sides: strengthening young people's readiness and access to opportunities while also encouraging employer participation and improving the conditions under which employment is created.

7.1 Integrated Intervention Framework

Stage	Intervention Area	Purpose
1. Prepare	Employment readiness and job-specific training	Develop relevant technical, digital, language, communication, and workplace-readiness competencies, with training linked to actual employment requirements.
2. Expose	Internships, apprenticeships, and practical work experience	Create structured opportunities for young people to gain workplace experience, apply their skills, and demonstrate their capabilities to employers.
3. Connect	Employer networking, mentorship, and professional exposure	Create direct and sustained connections between young people and employers while providing access to professional guidance and networks.
4. Guide	Career guidance and job-search support	Support young people in identifying suitable career pathways and improving their ability to navigate vacancies, applications, CVs, and interviews.
5. Match	Skills-based job matching and placement	Improve the connection between candidates and suitable vacancies by making skills, experience, and job requirements more transparent.
6. Sustain	Job quality, compensation, and working conditions	Encourage employment opportunities that are sufficiently attractive and sustainable for young workers, while addressing factors that may affect retention and the quality of employment.

7.2 A Two-Sided Approach to Youth Employment

Youth unemployment cannot be addressed solely by increasing the skills or employability of young people. The findings also point to the importance of employer participation and of the broader environment in which employment opportunities are created.

Target	Recommended Actions
Young people	Provide practical and job-specific training; strengthen workplace readiness; improve CV and interview preparation; develop digital and language competencies; and provide access to career guidance and professional mentorship.
Employers	Encourage participation in internships, apprenticeships, mentorship, and employer-linked training; strengthen entry-level recruitment pathways; and promote attractive working conditions and compensation.
Universities and training institutions	Develop stronger links with employers, incorporate practical workplace exposure into training, and align curricula and training content with evolving labour-market requirements.
Government and employment-support organizations	Support employer participation through appropriate incentives, expand accessible employment services, facilitate partnerships, and reduce practical barriers that may prevent young people from accessing opportunities.
Employment intermediaries	Develop reliable job-matching mechanisms that connect young people with relevant vacancies while providing employers with access to candidates whose skills and experience correspond to job requirements.

7.2.1 Building University–Employer Connections

A particularly important mechanism is the development of stronger connections between educational institutions and employers. Such partnerships can integrate several intervention areas into a single employment pathway.

Universities and employers can collaborate on internships, apprenticeships, employer-led projects, job-specific training, career events, mentorship, and early recruitment activities. This can reduce the distance between education and the workplace by giving young people earlier exposure to actual employment requirements while allowing employers to participate in the development and identification of emerging talent.

Such partnerships should not be limited to occasional recruitment events. A more sustainable model would establish continuous interaction between educational institutions, employers, students, and employment-support organizations.

7.2.2 Supporting the Transition from Training to Employment

Training should be connected to opportunities to apply newly acquired skills. A training programme that ends without a pathway toward workplace experience or employment may have limited impact on the transition from unemployment to work.

An integrated model can therefore connect:

Training → Practical Experience → Mentorship and Employer Exposure → Job Application → Employment

Within this pathway, career guidance and job-matching services can operate across the different stages, helping young people identify appropriate opportunities and helping employers reach suitable candidates.

7.2.3 Implementation Principles

The proposed interventions should follow several principles to maximize their relevance and sustainability.

Employer involvement. Employment and training initiatives should be designed with meaningful employer participation so that they remain connected to actual workplace requirements.

Practical orientation. Programs should prioritize applied learning, projects, workplace exposure, and demonstrable competencies rather than relying exclusively on theoretical instruction.

Accessibility and inclusion. Opportunities should remain accessible to young people who lack previous work experience, established professional networks, or financial resources to support an extended job search.

Mutual responsibility. Youth employment should be approached as a shared responsibility among young people, employers, educational institutions, government, and employment-support organizations rather than as an issue attributable to one side alone.

Sustainability. Interventions should aim not only to facilitate entry into employment but also to support employment that provides adequate working conditions, appropriate compensation, and opportunities for continued development.

7.2.4 Overall Implication

The evidence supports a coordinated approach to youth employment that combines preparation, practical experience, employer access, guidance, matching, and job quality.

The central implication is that improving youth employment requires more than preparing young people to compete for existing vacancies. Effective interventions should also create stronger pathways into employment, increase employer engagement, connect education with the labour market, and address the conditions under which young people enter and remain in work.

A successful employment strategy should therefore bridge three elements: **capability**, by ensuring that young people can develop and demonstrate relevant competencies; **access**, by creating meaningful connections with employers and employment opportunities; and **opportunity**, by encouraging the creation of accessible and sustainable entry-level employment.

8 Conclusion

This study examined youth unemployment in Lebanon from both the graduate job-seeker and employer perspectives. Rather than treating unemployment solely as a deficiency in job-seeker capabilities, the study examined the interaction between youth capabilities, employer expectations, recruitment practices, access to employment opportunities, and the availability of suitable jobs.

The analysis of unemployed youth identified the barriers, skills, employment preferences, and forms of support that shape their transition into employment. The employer analysis complemented this perspective by examining hiring expectations, recruitment practices, candidate selection, and the challenges organizations face when recruiting young people.

Bringing the two perspectives together revealed both areas of alignment and areas of mismatch. The findings indicate that youth unemployment cannot be adequately understood from either perspective alone. Some challenges relate to skills and practical experience, while others concern access to employers, career guidance, recruitment processes, job matching, and the availability and quality of employment opportunities.

The study therefore supports a two-sided approach to addressing youth unemployment. Interventions should strengthen young people's preparation and access to practical experience while simultaneously encouraging employer participation, stronger connections between education and the labour market, and more effective pathways into entry-level employment.

The proposed intervention framework provides a basis for translating these findings into action through employment readiness, practical experience, employer connections, career guidance, job matching, and improved employment conditions. Its central principle is that successful transition into employment requires more than acquiring skills: young people must also have opportunities to apply those skills, demonstrate their capabilities, access employers, and find suitable employment opportunities.

Overall, the study highlights the importance of moving from a one-dimensional view of youth unemployment toward a more integrated labour-market perspective. Bridging the gap between young people and employers requires coordinated action across individuals, employers, educational institutions, government, and employment-support organizations.

9 Analysis Code

The complete Python code used for data preprocessing, statistical analysis, comparative analysis, and visualization is available in the project's GitHub repository.

The repository contains the code required to reproduce the analyses presented in this report:

- Youth dataset analysis
- Employer dataset analysis
- Statistical summaries and cross-tabulations
- Data visualizations

GitHub Repository: [<https://github.com/BatoulBlaybel/Youth-Unemployment-in-Lebanon>]